আমাদের এই আলোচনা থেকে এটা বুঝতে পেরেছেন যে বাক্যের গাঠনিক বিশ্লেষণের শুরু থাকলেও শেষ নেই। তবে বাক্যের গঠনগত বৈচিত্র্য দেখতে চাইলে এবং বুঝতে চাইলে নিয়মিত পত্রিকা পড়ার বিকল্প নেই। এই কাজটা নিয়মিতভাবে করতে হবে। আপনি উন্নতি করবেন, এটা নিশ্চিত। এই পর্যায়ে, আমরা ১০ টি আর্টিকেল যা বিভিন্ন পত্রিকায় প্রকাশিত তা বইয়ে যুক্ত করেছি। একটু মন দিয়ে পড়বেন। শব্দ চয়ন এবং বাক্যের গঠন নিয়ে চিন্তা করবেন।

## NEWSPAPER SECTION

### 01. *Colonisation by debt*: *Where China begins as an economic partner of a country, and ends up its economic master*

***—By Brahma Chellaney***

American statesman John Adams famously said, "There are two ways to conquer and enslave a country: One is by the sword; the other is by debt." China, choosing the second path, has embraced colonial-era practices and rapidly emerged as the world's biggest official creditor.

With its international loans surpassing more than 5% of the global GDP, China has now eclipsed traditional lenders, including the World Bank, International Monetary Fund, and all the creditor nations of the Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) combined. By extending huge loans with strings attached to financially vulnerable states, it has not only boosted its leverage over them but also ensnared some in sovereignty-eroding debt traps.

The latest to fall prey to China's debt-trap diplomacy is Laos, which recently signed a 25-year concession agreement allowing a majority Chinese-owned company to control its national power grid. Instead of first evaluating a borrower country's creditworthiness, China is happy to lend, because the heavier the debt burden on the borrower, the greater China's own leverage becomes.

A new international study has shed light on China's muscular and exploitative lending practices by examining 100 of its loan contracts with 24 countries. The lopsided contracts, while curtailing the options of the borrowing nations, give China's state-owned banks untrammelled discretion, including the power to scrap loans or even demand full repayment ahead of schedule. China leverages its state-sponsored loans to aggressively advance its trade and geopolitical interests, with the study reporting pervasive links between Chinese financial, trade and construction contracts with other countries.

Many Chinese loans, in fact, have not been publicly disclosed, thus spawning a "hidden debt" problem. Every contract since 2014 has incorporated a sweeping confidentiality clause that compels the borrowing country to keep secret the terms or even the loan's existence. Such China-enforced opacity, as the study points out, breaches the principle that public debt should be public and not hidden from taxpayers so that governments can be held accountable.

Forcing the other side to keep contractual provisions under wraps is also necessitated by the fact that China's loan accords equip it with "broad latitude to cancel loans or accelerate repayment if it disagrees with a borrower's policies", whether domestic or foreign policy, according to the study. The contracts, the study found, also obligate the borrower to exclude the Chinese debt from any multilateral restructuring process, such as the Paris Club. This is aimed at ensuring that the borrowing country remains dependent on Beijing.

The study confirms that little of what China provides is aid or low-interest lending. Instead, its infrastructure financing comes mainly in the form of market-rate loans like those from private capital markets. The more dire the borrower's financial situation, the higher the interest rate China is likely to charge for lending money. In stark contrast, interest rates for Japan's infrastructure loans to developing countries mostly run below half a percent. Many of China's loan contracts also incorporate collateral arrangements.

The study did not examine how borrowing states, when unable to repay Chinese loans, are compelled to cede strategic assets to China. Water-rich Laos's transfer of its national electric grid to Chinese majority control holds implications for its water resources too as hydropower makes up more than four-fifths of national electricity generation.

One of China's earliest successes was in securing 1,158 square kilometres of strategic territory from Tajikistan in 2011 in exchange for debt forgiveness. Since then, as the Chinese military base in Badakhshan underscores, China has further consolidated its foothold in Tajikistan, thanks to a corrupt power elite there.

A more famous example is the Sri Lankan transfer of the Hambantota Port, along with more than 6,000 hectares of land around it, to Beijing on a 99-year lease. The concept of a 99-year lease, ironically, emerged from the flurry of European colonial expansion in China in the 19th century. The transfer of the Indian Ocean region's most strategically located port in late 2017 was seen in Sri Lanka as the equivalent of a heavily indebted farmer giving away his daughter to the cruel money lender.

China's debt-trap diplomacy has not spared even its close ally Pakistan. Saddled with huge Chinese debt, Pakistan has given China exclusive rights, coupled with a tax holiday, to run Gwadar Port for the next four decades, with Beijing also pocketing 91% of the port's revenues. China also plans to build near Gwadar a Djibouti-style outpost for its navy.

In small island nations, China has converted big loans into acquisition of entire islets through exclusive development rights. China took over a couple of islets in the Indian Ocean archipelago of the Maldives and one island in the South Pacific nation of the Solomon Islands. The European Union, meanwhile, has refused to bail out the tiny Balkan republic of Montenegro for mortgaging itself to China.

China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) has been plagued by allegations of corruption and malpractice, and many of its completed projects have proved not financially viable. But, as an unclassified US intelligence report released on April 13 said, Beijing will continue to promote BRI, while fine-tuning it. After all, BRI is central to its debt-trap diplomacy. China often begins as an economic partner of a small, financially weak country, only to gradually become its economic master.

***Source:* Colonisation by debt: Where China begins as an economic partner of a country, and ends up its economic master (indiatimes.com) *May 11, 2021, 7:36 AM IST* Brahma Chellaney *in* TOI Edit Page, Edit Page, India, World, *TOI***

## 02. *Surging government borrowing portrays a grim future*
### *—By Birupaksha Paul*

Government borrowing from the banking sector has been rising alarmingly since the end of the pandemic. The government took around Tk 98,000 crore in loans from Bangladesh Bank in the 2022-23 fiscal year – which was 44 percent of the total deficit, suggesting excessive borrowing. Borrowing is used to plug the budget deficit, but enough acumen on economics and finance must be exercised to decide the sources of borrowing since different sources can lead to different repercussions on growth and the economic future. Recent trends seem to care too little about the wise art of deficit financing.

Government borrowing from the banking sector has been rising alarmingly since the end of the pandemic. The government took around Tk 98,000 crore in loans from Bangladesh Bank in the 2022-23 fiscal year – which was 44 percent of the total deficit, suggesting excessive borrowing. Borrowing is used to plug the budget deficit, but enough acumen on economics and finance must be exercised to decide the sources of borrowing since different sources can lead to different repercussions on growth and the economic future. Recent trends seem to care too little about the wise art of deficit financing.

If this trend of chronic fiscal incapacity continues, a 10-year projection from now would land the nation at a budget deficit of around Tk 44 or so out of Tk 100 – which will be disastrous if the government's taxing capacity cannot be rescued from the disease of pampering the super-rich. Not displeasing the oligarchs and tycoons by imposing progressive tax rates on them lies at the root of the gradual collapse in our fiscal capacity, whose pernicious impact has been pushing the banking sector from bad to worse. And the finance sector is heading to an unsustainable state thereby depicting a grim future for the nation.

While borrowing from other commercial banks will create crowding out effects by depriving the private sector from availing loans, borrowing from the central bank is a double-edged sword for stoking inflation and promoting further fiscal incapacity. The stubbornly high inflation at double digits, and the government's increased fiscal borrowing over the post-pandemic years, are bitter testimonies to the claim that a bleak future for the economy looms on the horizon unless the finance ministry pulls the bridle of the fiscal spending and accelerates its capacity to increase the amount and base for tax collection. The government should consider building a separate ministry for the entire revenue collection system since the finance ministry shows no improvements regarding expected tax collection.

The FY2013 budget occupied 18.24 percent of GDP while the government was able to manage 14 percent of GDP as revenue. The FY2023 budget captured an even lower share of GDP, only 14.9 percent, while the government's revenue management reached another low at 9.9 percent. The revenue-to-GDP ratio should naturally step up as an economy moves up on the development ladder. Of course, the economy is developing but the super-rich are not contributing the fair share of their increased capacity to the public coffers simply because the tycoons can make public institutions act in their favour and eschew paying appropriate taxes in order to balloon their fortunes.

This kind of symbiotic relationship between the affluent and the regime is perilous for the future of the economy. And the relationship has recently turned into hyperactive endorsements from both sides as the election bell rings. The FY2024 budget projects to increase the revenue-to-GDP ratio to over 20 percent in the future. No matter how farcical that kind of utterance is, the ministry did not give any timeline, implying the vagueness of the statement. In contrast, take, for example, the growing economy of Vietnam where the average revenue-to-GDP ratio from 2020 to 2022 has remained above 15 percent.

In Bangladesh, 63 percent of the fiscal deficit of the FY2023 budget was financed from domestic sources, and the remaining 37 percent from foreign counterparts. The banking sector alone gave 52 percent of the fiscal deficit while the amount borrowed from the central bank was as high as 44 percent. The "beauty" of borrowing from the central bank is that eventually the government does not pay anything for the interest burden because the central bank's income is ultimately the government's earnings. That is why most emerging governments prevent this damaging practice from happening by imposing a law against this kind of easy debt monetisation. India passed the Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management Act, 2003 to stop automatic monetisation of the fiscal debt. Bangladesh requires a similar act to check the current trend of fiscal trespassing into the territory of the central bank.

The worst effect of the government's borrowing from the central bank surfaces through the high-octane pressures on inflation – different from that of other modes of financing. The central bank gives high-powered money to the government, and it has higher multiplier effects on money creation. Thus, borrowing from Sonali Bank versus Bangladesh Bank is fundamentally different in fuelling inflation. The magnitude is much higher once the government borrows money directly from the central bank. That is another reason why Bangladesh's inflation even in July 2023 remained over double digits, while the inflation rate for other comparable economies including India has dropped to almost half of ours.

The government's borrowing from the banking sector over FY2024 will be even higher, as predicted. The default loans will go up as the trend suggests. Businessmen will prepare excuses, citing political disruptions in the lead-up to the upcoming national election. The pressure from both the government and the habitual defaulters will squeeze the lending space for banks, making the cost of funds more expensive for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). This will discourage investment, which will in turn impede GDP growth and growth in employment. The only rescue plan from this conundrum is to drastically enhance tax collection from business groups, noted tycoons, habitual defaulters, and doubted money launderers. There is no Plan B in this respect.

***Source:*** ***Surging government borrowing portrays a grim future | The Daily Star***
***Sun Aug 6, 2023 09:00 AM, Last update on: Sun Aug 6, 2023 09:00 AM***

## 03. *Can the leather industry rise up to the occasion*?

***— Wasi Ahmed***

That the country earns only $1.7 billion from leather and footwear export appears rather intriguing to many. While there were forecasts terming the sector of leather and leather goods the next growth driver, and some efforts were also underway to translate the potential into reality, it is yet to meet the projected objective. There were lengthy narratives on finding the right course of action in order to energise the sector. It seemed alright so far as the dos and don'ts were pointed out, but the problem remained with the initiatives taken not in an organised and systematic manner.

In the recently held Bangladesh Leather Footwear & Leather goods International Sourcing Show (BLISS-2023), foreign and local speakers deliberated on the subject at some length. Though most of the issues were pretty well known to the sector insiders as well as those interested in the country's leather industry, repeating those was a strong reminder to get to business if the industry meant to ride out its current bottlenecks. Discussions were held mostly on how to access the global chain with procurement protocols getting stiffer than ever before. The discussions took place in a session titled 'Linking Bangladesh to Global Value Chain'.

The key issue highlighted by the speakers at the event was corporate sustainability reporting which broadly refers to compliance with increasing global rules and regulations alongside ensuring decent workplace, human rights and labour rights. They also said exporters and manufacturers in Bangladesh need to review their strengths and weaknesses to find out why, despite the potential, the country's leather and footwear export is languishing. They emphasised on global compliance as an essential prerequisite to get integrated into the global value chain, and urged fellow manufacturers and exporters to review their limitations and work on target-oriented markets. Besides local industry leaders, speakers at the event represented Sustainable Leather Foundation (SLF), GTZ, and a few other renowned international entities.

At the meeting some industry leaders sounded upbeat in view of some progress in sourcing finished raw-materials, especially for footwear. But achieving a substantial growth from where the industry stands now seems rather too ambitious.

However, the prospect of the industry to thrive up to the expectation has never been far from sight. Since low wage compared to most leather manufacturing countries is an alluring factor, chances of relocation of leather factories from other countries-China to be precise-seemed to be around the corner some time ago. Besides relocation of factories producing low-end products, foreign investment in a big way seemed likely, given what is often drummed up as the country's investment-friendly climate. Unfortunately, speculation did not help as nothing actually happened to revamp the sector.

There is no denying the fact that the country's leather sector is the victim of a lack of timely moves in the right direction. Absence of time-bound action plan in respect of facilitations such as central effluent treatment plan (CETP), fiscal restructuring, compliance conformity, value addition etc are some of the core issues that have been hindering the industry's smooth operations, particularly in exports. All that the government did was relocation of the tannery hub to Savar, but has there been any noticeable improvement in terms of fulfilling compliance norms?

Given that export is the sole motivation of the age-old industry, any move or policy must address barriers affecting exports--- be that in terms of physical infrastructure of the leather estate, environmental concern from pollution, compliance norms of the importing countries, testing, fiscal measures etc. Over the years, there were moves, rather like damage-control measure instead of the pro-active with an eye for the market trend, which did not bring any significant improvement to energise the industry.

Bangladesh's current share in the $215 billion global leather and leather goods market is only 0.5 per cent. This, industry experts hold, is appallingly short of the country's actual potential. Keeping this in view, industry leaders have been suggesting for time-bound policy support to complement the 'Leather and Leather Goods Development Policy 2019'.

While addressing the compliance norms, the major hurdle that has rendered the country's leather industry out of pace is obviously the nonfunctional Central Effluent Plant (CETP) at the Savar leather industrial estate. CETP continues to be a stumbling block on way to export. The Leather Working Group (LWG) certification is now a precondition for accessing global market but it cannot be obtained without a functional CETP, solid waste management and chrome recovery units in the tannery estate. So much has been said on this issue for years but no noticeable move is in sight, as of now. It is indeed intriguing that CETP being the most essential component of the leather estate, the facility could be subjected to such neglect by the authorities for years.

***Source:*** ***https://thefinancialexpress.com.bd/views/columns/can-the-leather-industry-rise-up-to-the-occasion***

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## 04. *America's Interest in Ending the Ukraine Crisis*

***—By Birupaksha Paul***

After more than a year of fighting, it is clear that neither side in the Russia-Ukraine war can win on the battlefield. A negotiated ceasefire is the only way out of the current military deadlock, and it must happen before Russia and China cement a strategic axis that weakens the West and leaves Taiwan more vulnerable than ever.

NEW DELHI – The recent face-to-face meeting in New Delhi between US Secretary of State Antony Blinken and Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov – the first such high-level interaction since the start of Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine – suggests that diplomacy may no longer be a dirty word.

The ten-minute meeting on the sidelines of the G20 gathering occurred after US National Security Adviser Jake Sullivan reportedly urged Ukraine to show Russia that it is open to negotiating an end to the war. Together, these recent developments offer a glimmer of hope that a ceasefire is within the realm of the possible.

The war in Ukraine, which has shaken the foundations of the international order, is in many ways a proxy war between the world's two major powers, with Russia backed by China and Ukraine backed by the United States. Over the past year, the war has triggered global energy and food crises, spurred higher inflation amid slowing global growth, and heightened the risks – underscored by Russia's recent downing of a US drone over the Black Sea – of a direct Russia-NATO conflict.

And yet, after more than a year of fighting, it is clear that the conflict has settled into a war of attrition, with both sides struggling to make significant advances on the battlefield. A ceasefire is the only way out of this military deadlock, but reaching an agreement could take a long time. The 1950-53 Korean War, for example, was deadlocked for two years before an armistice agreement was reached.

Russian President Vladimir Putin clearly believes that a prolonged war of attrition works in his favor, enabling his army to wreak havoc on Ukraine and testing Western resolve. To overwhelm Ukrainian air defenses, Russia is launching more missiles simultaneously, including its Kinzhal hypersonic weapons, which are all but impossible to shoot down. Despite the flood of Western weapons systems it has received, Ukraine is in no position to thwart Russia's intensifying aerial assaults.

But it is also becoming increasingly clear that Russia cannot achieve its strategic objective in Ukraine. It may have occupied nearly one-fifth of the country's territory but it has created a more hostile neighbor and reinvigorated NATO, which is now poised to admit Finland and most likely Sweden. Moreover, many of the unprecedented sanctions the West has imposed on Russia will likely endure beyond the war and inflict long-lasting damage on the Russian economy.

At the same time, US President Joe Biden's "hybrid war" strategy, which seeks to cripple Russia through soft-power techniques and the weaponization of global finance, has failed to bring about Putin's downfall or turn the ruble into "rubble," as Biden vowed in the early stages of the war. The US-led sanctions regime has severely limited Russia's ability to resupply its forces but has fallen short of halting the Kremlin's war machine. While the sanctions have dented its earnings from energy exports, Russia has found willing buyers for its oil and natural gas in non-Western markets (albeit at a discount).

Short of a collapse in morale causing Russian soldiers to surrender en masse – which is a possibility, given the history of the Russian army – it is unlikely that Ukraine will be able to force Russia to withdraw fully from the territories it has occupied in the country's east and south. While the US has committed to upholding Ukraine's territorial integrity, restoring Ukrainian control over these regions seems like a distant goal at best.

Meanwhile, China is the only country that stands to benefit from a protracted conflict. As a recent report by the Washington, DC-based Free Russia Foundation says, China is already the "biggest winner" from the Western sanctions on Russia. China has become Russia's banker and most important trade partner, using the war to implement an energy safety net by securing greater Russian oil and gas supplies that could not be disrupted even if China decided to invade Taiwan.

The more the US is dragged into the war in Ukraine, the greater the likelihood that China invades Taiwan and America realizes its worst geopolitical nightmare: a Sino-Russian strategic axis. The US may remain the world's foremost military power for now, but taking on the combined force of China and Russia would be a herculean task.

The war has already exposed the West's military shortcomings, such as depletion of supplies of critical munitions, America's struggle to scale up weapons manufacturing, and the weakening of the US-European consensus on Ukraine. All this could tempt Chinese President Xi Jinping to seek to deplete Western arsenals further before invading Taiwan, by indirectly shipping arms to Russia and forcing the US and other governments to increase weapons supplies to Ukraine. Xi is already aiding Putin's war to a limited extent by supplying Russia and sanctioned Russian entities with drones, navigation equipment, jamming technology, fighter-jet parts, and semiconductors.

While some in the West believe that a negotiated ceasefire in Ukraine would embolden China to attack Taiwan, Xi does not need Russia to show him that aggression works. China's own cost-free expansionism, from the South China Sea to the Himalayas, is all the proof he needs.

As a recent RAND report points out, a protracted Ukraine war is not in America's interest. A prolonged conflict would lead to increased flows of US money and weapons into Ukraine, elevating the risk of a NATO-Russia conflict and hindering the ability of the US to respond to the China challenge. As Biden has already acknowledged, a "negotiated settlement" is the only way to end the war – better to seek it now than after months or years of bloodshed and devastation.

***Source:https://www.project-syndicate.org/commentary/prolonged-ukraine-war-only-china-benefits-by-brahma-chellaney-2023-03?fbclid=IwAR1xjY3VtgWM56IUGWDxUFqVj6J4qY9At0sgOI_oS1cgjl-e_957vlx6swE&barrier=accesspaylog***

## 05. *The real cost of de − dollarisation*
### *−By Benn Steil*

At the end of World War II, the United States accounted for more than half the world's economic output and gold reserves. The United Kingdom was effectively bankrupt, with the remnants of the sterling area bound together by capital and trade controls. Once the British pound became convertible in July 1947, owing to US insistence, it succumbed to overwhelming selling pressure. The dollar, which was pegged to gold at $35 an ounce, was buoyed by America's privileged position within the newly formed International Monetary Fund and quickly established itself as the bedrock of global trade and finance.

While the US today accounts for only 25 percent of global output, the dollar remains involved in nearly 90 percent of all foreign-exchange transactions. Despite its central role in cross-border trade and borrowing, however, the greenback's share of central-bank foreign-exchange reserves has fallen from 72 percent in 2000 to 59 percent today. Given recent harsh criticism of US currency policy by officials in China, Russia, Brazil, Saudi Arabia, and elsewhere, it may therefore appear that the dollar's uncontested reign is coming to an end, with far-reaching global economic consequences.

Importantly, the biggest threat to the dollar's dominance comes not from competitive alternatives, but from the US government itself. The recent standoff over the federal debt ceiling, which threatened to trigger global financial instability, is a case in point. The prospect of endless repetition of such reckless partisan conflict prompted Fitch Ratings to downgrade the country's credit rating from AAA to AA+, highlighting doubts about whether global investors can continue to trust the "full faith and credit of the US government."

But an even more immediate threat to the greenback's dominance is its growing weaponisation. Whereas US-led sanctions have been largely ineffective in changing the behaviour of autocratic regimes in North Korea, Iran, and Russia, they have inflicted considerable economic pain. And just as the overuse of antibiotics fuels antimicrobial resistance, excessive use of sanctions prompts targeted countries, as well as potential targets, to reduce their engagement with the US financial system. Although this avoidance is costly, the costs are trivial compared to those of, say, having one's central-bank reserves frozen, or even seized. Prominent US commentators have advocated such seizures in the case of Russia, in order to compensate Ukraine for the horrific costs of Russia's invasion.

But if the dollar should lose its privileged place, what could replace it? At present, the euro, which accounts for 20 percent of global central-bank reserves, is the only currency that could realistically serve as a substitute. Its appeal, however, is undermined by the fragmentation of Europe's national sovereign-debt markets, as well as lingering doubts about the European Union's long-term viability in the wake of the UK's departure.

The Chinese renminbi, which accounts for less than 3 percent of global reserves, is not a serious threat to dollar hegemony. Given China's deteriorating legal protections, stringent capital controls, and relatively underdeveloped bond markets – from which foreign investors pulled a record $91 billion in 2022 – the renminbi is still far from a credible store of value. The currency's internationalisation stalled a decade ago when capital inflows driven by expectations of perpetual appreciation came to an end.

So, whereas the dollar's continued dominance should not be taken for granted, there is currently no viable single alternative. Instead, many commentators have pointed to the probable emergence of a "multi-currency" world in which the dollar plays a much-diminished role. Such a world, however, is not compatible with the multilateral trading system as we know it.

To be sure, countries can sidestep the dollar through barter trade, using commodities such as gold or oil. Iraq, for example, swaps oil with Iran in exchange for natural gas. But governments will not accumulate currencies for which they and their citizens have no practical use. Thus, the greenback's fading dominance could mark the demise of a highly efficient structure of global commerce in which the flow of goods and services is determined by cost and quality. Instead, this flow would reflect whether a bit more or less of a given foreign currency is wanted in an exporting country.

Once countries abandon the practice of stockpiling currency through current-account surpluses, they are compelled to implement trade restrictions and other distortive measures to maintain flat bilateral trade balances. That is why the dollar, despite its drawbacks as a global reserve currency, remains integral to the multilateral trade system built up under the 1947 General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade and its successor, the World Trade Organization. Although this regime is often criticised in the US for helping China rise through mercantilist means, it has played a critical role in spurring global innovation, reducing costs, and lifting hundreds of millions out of poverty.

Although the US can and should do more, through better education and job training, and stronger social safety nets, to support its citizens left behind by globalisation, it must also ensure that its currency remains reliable enough to continue supporting world trade. That means putting an end to periodic partisan default brinkmanship, and exercising greater prudence and restraint in the use of unilateral financial sanctions.

***Source: https://www.thedailystar.net/opinion/views/news/the-real-cost-de-dollarisation-3396356***
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## 06. *Taming inflation thru flexible taxation*

The idea of setting different tariffs for agricultural commodities based on their production calendar sounds good, for its basic objective is to protect the interests of domestic producers, consumers and the government. But its execution might prove daunting because of a host of factors. The Bangladesh Trade and Tariff Commission (BTTC), according to a report published in this paper, has floated a proposal designed to provide relief to the inflation-hit consumers and protect the interests of the farm goods producers without affecting the government's revenue earnings.

It is not hard to understand why authorities are trying to find ways to tame the runaway food inflation. This is, after all, election year and increasingly the general populace is beginning to believe that the State is complicit in the act of fleecing consumers of their precious earnings at the retail markets along with the perceived 'market syndicates'. The good deeds on the infrastructure side are being marred by something fundamental - the unimaginable rise in cost of food!

Half-hearted interventions initiated from time to time have had no impact on prices and hence a different way of taming the prices of essentials is being explored. Although there is contention amongst economists about whether these measures would make much of a dent as it is their opinion that authorities need to put a lot more emphasis on market monitoring to break up the so-called syndicates that are thought to be responsible for the price volatility in the first place.

As pointed out by the Chairman of the Research and Policy Integration for Rapid Development (RAPID), Dr. Mohammad Abdur Razzaq, "market management is important to rein in the prices of essential commodities. The government will have to build a data bank of essential commodity supply to take proper decision." The idea of a seasonal tariff regime revolves around the imposition of varying tariffs on farm produce during harvesting season to protect the interests of farmers and

consumers. As per plan, these tariffs would be fixed at the beginning of a year on the basis of harvesting calendar of agricultural products.

To what end such measures would be effective is in doubt. Given the propensity of importers to give false declarations to bring in products in a manner to dodge customs and tax authorities, it may prove to be a tall order to implement this new tax regime. Again, it is understood from experience that any tariff cut to tame prices of commodities is a long-drawn process under the current bureaucratic system. Hence, there is suspicion whether this raft of measures would actually bring about any benefit to either farmers or consumers.

Although the ministry of commerce is confident that this new measure will work, it all depends on what sort of policy guideline is in place to make good use of this plan. Doubts have risen about whether the government has access to the right data concerning the production of different agricultural commodities in the country. Authorities are now hamstrung by poor quality data which make it next to impossible to plan effectively. It would be much easier if authorities decided to go after unscrupulous players in the supply chain of essential foods with anti-racketeering measures, including incarceration, to have a positive impact on prices.

***Source: https://thefinancialexpress.com.bd/editorial/taming-inflation-thru-flexible-taxation***
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## 07. *Regaining denim primacy*

Denim, acclaimed as a highly prospective growth driver of the country's garment industry, has begun to shed its shine in the export market. A piece of bad news no doubt — a sudden decline in the primacy of Bangladeshi denim in the global market is attributable to not only better performance of the competitors but to a host of other factors also. In fact, the EU-GSP was largely instrumental in making the headway for Bangladeshi manufacturers and exporters of denim products backed by orderly and efficient supply chain management. However, global inflation followed by consumer austerity in recent times coupled with the rise in cost of production is believed to have caused the export slump.

A FE report quoting industry sources says that Bangladesh is losing its competitive edge to Turkey, Mexico and Pakistan mainly because of the high cost of production triggered among other factors by costly dollar. The country dominated the global denim market with its sustained position as top supplier to two major export destinations — the United States and the European Union — on a high annual growth in 2022. Bangladesh had earned US$943.70 million and US$1.55 billion from US and EU market respectively in 2022, becoming the top denim supplier. The country earned US$561.29 million and US$798.42 million from the US market while US$1.02 billion and US$1.18 billion from the EU respectively in 2020 and 2021. However, during the first half of 2023, denim exports to the USA and the European Union saw 33 per cent and 22.48 per cent negative growth respectively. Denim exports fetched Bangladesh US$298.75 million from the USA in January-June period of this calendar year — down from 445.52 million in the corresponding period of the last year. Demand for denim garments in the US declined 29.34 per cent - from $ 2.05 billion in the first half of 2022 to $ 1.44 billion in the corresponding period of 2023. There is also a marked fall in EU's denim imports from the world by 17.19 per cent during the period.

While inflationary pressure accounts for the overall slump in global apparel market, in case of Bangladesh, according to the industry people, it is the high cost of production prompted by gas price hike and gap in foreign currency price in the kerb market and official rate that is adversely affecting export of denim garments.

There is more to these. It has been learnt that Bangladeshi suppliers are finding it difficult to cope with the changing pattern of denim export orders. The long-run orders for a single-style design are now being replaced with multi-style designs. According to an exporter quoted in the aforementioned FE report, in order to cope with the changing trend of export orders, the production line has to be changed into what is known as 'modular system' with skilled workers capable of performing multiple tasks. This clearly necessitates suitable transformation for sustainable production processes. Concerned quarters will hopefully put in their best to do the needful for regaining the denim market.

***Source: https://thefinancialexpress.com.bd/editorial/the-minimum-wage-rmg-workers-deserve***
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## 08. *Big budget, bigger corruption*

***—By Mahfuz Anam***

In democracy, there are two types of accountability of the government: first, to the people who elect them, and second, to itself so that it can survive the wrath of public judgement.

This it does by knowing and monitoring whether it is fulfilling its election pledges and whether its own policies and projects are being implemented properly. This happens when the political forces it represents and the government institutions it runs work honestly, efficiently and for the public good. This is otherwise known as "governance," which can principally be assured by institutionalising "accountability."

This is where the present government has mostly failed, resulting in severely discrediting itself, crippling most institutions – through corruption and cronyism – and demoralising the youth by practising a culture of impunity.

Let's start with a small example of accountability failure – but one that is highly symbolic.

On November 28, the newly launched Dainik Bangla published a report titled "Taka thakley jail o mukto jiboner moto (If you have money, life in jail is as good as life outside)." The story details how bribery starts the moment one enters the four principal prisons in Bangladesh, and how money can ensure better accommodation, better diet, better living facilities including access to TV and a mobile phone – the latter often used for running illegal business, and even terrorist activities. While going for obligatory court appearances, arrangements can be made for a family visit. Like hotels, you can book hospital accommodation priced at Tk 10,000 for the first week, and half that amount for subsequent weeks. Yaba and other narcotics are also available. Officials know all this, but cannot or will not do anything about it.

Prisons are supposedly under full control of the authorities. If criminal activities cannot be controlled inside, how can the public trust the same authorities to control it outside?

A second example of accountability failure deals with delays in project implementation and the enormous cost escalation, with no one being questioned as to why. According to Jugantor of November 28, there was an additional cost of more than Tk 52,000 crore for 10 megaprojects caused by faulty designs, lack of proper feasibility study, additional work, lack of proper leadership and supervision, delay in release of funds, and other reasons. Not a single project was finished on schedule and the time extensions ranged from two to nine years, and still counting. Total funds allocated for these 10 projects amounted to Tk 63,757 crore. These are now estimated to cost Tk 116,198 crore.

A saying prevalent from the colonial days goes like this, "Sarkar ka maal, dariya mey dhal (If it is government money, it is okay to throw it in the sea)." Only now, instead of throwing it into the sea, we put it in our pockets. The Office of the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) may raise audit objections, but who has the time to look into them? And it does not pay to do so.

Here again, we raise the point of why no one has been held accountable for such an enormous waste of money. With Tk 52,000 crore, probably every nook and corner of Dhaka city's roads and its essential water supply could have been modernised. Not to be forgotten that the aforementioned amount is for only the 10 projects in question. Literally, there are a hundred others like them.

As for monitoring, there is a body called the Implementation, Monitoring and Evaluation Division (IMED) under the planning ministry. We occasionally hear about their reports, but without much impact as both time extension and cost escalation continue unabated.

Perhaps the most dangerous lapse of accountability is in the financial sector. This writer, in his column of November 17, drew attention to the rise of default loans from Tk 4,646 crore in 1990 to Tk 134,396 crore today – a growth of 29 times in nearly as many years. Here again, the truth is nothing has been done to remedy the situation except to pander to the culprits, which defies all logic and national interest. An exasperated High Court judge reprimanded, just a few days ago, an Anti-Corruption Commission (ACC) lawyer, saying, "Will the big loan defaulters remain untouched? They are misappropriating thousands of crores. The commission is busy catching small-time loan defaulters, but not the big ones."

News of the last few days dealing with loan disbursement of Tk 7,246 crore by the Islami Bank Bangladesh Ltd (IBBL) has shaken the financial sector and have raised serious questions about the monitoring and oversight role of the Bangladesh Bank (BB).

The IBBL disbursed Tk 7,246 crore this year to nine companies that were sister concerns of Rajshahi-based Nabil Group, of which Tk 2,460 crore were issued during 17 days of November. The bank officials told this newspaper that most of the companies gave fake addresses in their loan applications. How can that be? An address is one of the first things that banks check before considering any loan application – and that, too, one amounting to thousands of crores.

There are many more lapses that are unthinkable in the case of large loan disbursement. Either the IBBL staff have forgotten their trade, or its high-ups are more eager to loot it than to run it properly.

It must be mentioned here that the Islami Bank was once among the best banks run in the country. A few years back, it was suddenly taken over and a new board of directors, with a majority of new members and a new chair, was put in charge along with a new MD and some senior officials. How the changeover took place remains a mystery, but its effect is clear now. Surprisingly, the BB, which now monitors even the personal travels of bank MDs, did not take any serious note of this sudden and unexplained – to the public and especially to its depositors – takeover of the biggest private bank of the country.

What the accountability of BB or the finance ministry on this score is, remains a question.

The LC-related story of the Social Islami Bank Ltd (SIBL), which is currently making the rounds, is equally – if not more – horrendous if the BB investigation proves so. Sharpe Knitting and Dyeing Ltd has been using a bonded warehouse facility without exporting a single item. In the process, it has reportedly misappropriated about Tk 16,500 crore over a period of seven years.

Lack of accountability created the environment for this to happen.

At the very moment, banks have become burdened with so much mismanagement and loan defaults that the government amended the law to allow members of the same family to have a larger number of seats in banks' boards and for longer periods than before. This greatly increased family control of banks and weakened professional managers' power to enforce compliance and financial discipline.

Another nail in the accountability requirements.

Bigger budgets, bigger projects, bigger funding, bigger loans being defaulted, bigger corruption, bigger siphoning of project money, bigger amounts of laundered money, bigger houses in Malaysia and Canada, and lesser and lesser accountability.

A role model, indeed.

Post-script

This week, the finance minister asked the press, "How is the state of the banking sector bad? Let us know in writing and we will look into it." Obviously, he doesn't read the newspapers. Doesn't he have a huge staff to keep him informed? The minister does not know, so does it mean that his ministry does not know either? If they don't, then what are they doing, and do they deserve the salary and perks for which the public pay? If they do know, then why doesn't their minister know? There were numerous media reports recently on mega loans to dubious business houses. The Bangladesh Bank has initiated inquiries of its own on some loan disbursements by Sonali Bank Ltd, asking it to be stopped for now. The Parliamentary Committee on Estimates recently issued a report stating, "Sonali Bank's loan situation is frightening."

Yet, the finance minister knows nothing. His ignorance is highly irresponsible, extremely dangerous and totally unacceptable, especially at this critical time.

***Source: https://www.thedailystar.net/opinion/the-third-view/news/big-budget-bigger-corruption-3184751***
***Thu Dec 1, 2022 11:00 PM; Last update on: Thu Dec 1, 2022 11:00 PM***

## 09. *A ghostly landscape of Palestinian graves*

***—By SYED BADRUL AHSAN***

They are all stationed in important western capitals. And they are all looking away from the terror that has descended on Palestinians in Gaza. They are all lining up behind Netanyahu, to let him know that in his war against the innocent in Gaza they are with him.

They are not, have never been with the Palestinians in these past so many years. These people without a state, inhabiting the ghetto Gaza has been turned into, have borne the brunt of Jewish settler violence and Israeli military might. These powerful men and women in the West have had no time for these Palestinians.

These men and women of enormous power have spoken of the need for Israel to exist free of danger. They have looked away from the danger into which Netanyahu and his far-right government have pushed these hapless Palestinians. They do not see, they do not wish to acknowledge the war crimes the Palestinian people are being subjected to, month after month, year after year.

They condemn Hamas terrorism. They do not speak of the terror their friends in Tel Aviv rain down on people who have no means of defending themselves – no army, no air force, no navy, no formal structure of what constitutes a state. They are not worried when Israel's cabinet orders a blockade of Gaza, prevents food, water, electricity and aid from going in.

They stand solidly behind the men whose savagery is pounding Gaza into rubble, life into unmoving flesh, families into memories of those bloodied to death. They see buildings and homes and offices slipping into ash. But they look away.

They have no inclination to see conditions for what those conditions are. They see the terror machine of a state mowing down lives. And yet they do not perceive circumstances for what they are. For these men and women, the swift murder of those Gazans is no war crime. It is Israel's act of self-defence, even if Netanyahu has promised revenge on an entire population for the action of a militant group craving freedom for its people.

Look away from Gaza for a while, to take in the hypocrisy these men and women of unlimited, unchallenged power have exhibited elsewhere around the world. They have always condemned the Chinese over the alleged repression exercised on the Uyghurs. They have condemned President Vladimir Putin over his assault on Ukraine, have gone looking for evidence of Russian war crimes, have had sanctions imposed on the Russian leader.

These powerful men and women, operating in Washington, London, Paris, Berlin and Brussels, draw a veil over the crimes, crimes against humanity, being committed by a government whose country has stood on territory that was once an entirety of Palestine.

These individuals of power miss no opportunity to take Iran's ayatollahs to task over the human rights being violated in Tehran and elsewhere in the country. But Iran's rulers have not bombed people in regions beyond Iran. And yet for these powerful individuals Iran is a potent threat. Israel is not.

Time was when such powerful western leaders sat in comfortable couches even as some among their own went into destroying Iraq in 2003. No provocation was there for George W. Bush and Tony Blair, except the WMD lie they invented and repeated ad nauseam, to march into Baghdad, topple Iraq's government and unleash the fury that would put the country to the torch.

The world, the western hemisphere, looked away at the time. The western hemisphere is looking away from Gaza now. To all intents and purposes, Palestinians either do not exist or they have turned subhuman, undeserving of the attention of the putatively civilised world. Palestine was buried under the weight of Israel in May 1948. Its soul refuses to die.

And Palestinians have trekked from country to country in search of bare existence. In the world's power capitals, they are not seen on the radar. They carry begging bowls, they live on the aid doled out by global bodies and charity organisations. In a world of power and prosperity, these Palestinians always stand outside the door for scraps of sympathy.

Hearts in the West have grown hard and cold. Sympathy is not to be found there for these people whose grandparents and parents were driven out of their homes and villages in 1948. Hearts melt --- and they should – when innocent men and women die in Hamas missile raids on Ashkelon. But hearts do not melt when Palestinians have their lives snuffed out in Netanyahu's revenge mission.

The United Nations informs the world that 187,000 of Gaza's 2.3 million people have left their homes in search of shelter since Netanyahu's offensive went underway. Back in 2014, Israel's aggressive air and ground offensive forced 400,000 Gazans out of their homes. These men and women, in their hubristic hold on authority, said nothing nine years ago. They will say nothing in 2023.

And that is the pity. These western human symbols of power, fond of lecturing governments in less powerful or weak nations on democracy and human rights and rule of law, will not lecture Israel. Those Hamas missiles were a violation of the sanctity of life. These Israeli bombs falling on

Palestinian homes, on old and young and babies, are for these powerful men and women no violation of life's noble principles.

For these powerful rulers of the world, life is of little consequence in Afghanistan, where people perish in hunger, where girls cannot go to school, where government is based on the primitive and on an endless use of the lash on women. They lorded it over Afghanistan as purveyors of neo-colonialism, before abandoning it to the wolves.

Their ancestors abandoned the Palestinians decades ago, for what mattered was the Balfour Declaration. It did not matter that Palestinian homes, their villages, their olive gardens, their heritage, their songs were pushed into exile. And so it does not matter today that the descendants of those exiles are paying for the sins of western colonialism, that they carry their dead and bloodied babies to cemeteries in the narrow confines of Gaza.

The numbers go up. Illegal Jewish settlements spread out across occupied territory. Palestinian graves extend as far as the eye can see.

But those men and women, immaculate in their demonstration of authority in the world's elegant and well-ordered capitals, do not have time to see such manifestations of reality. The blood on the streets of Gaza does not move them.

No hint of statesmanship lights up their politics. Absence of moral leadership turns them into hollow men.

***Source: https://thefinancialexpress.com.bd/views/columns/a-ghostly-landscape-of-palestinian-graves***
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## 10. *Climate change is making us sick*

***—By Naveen Rao, Eloise Todd***

A day before the latest United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP27) began, a group of global experts convened by *The Lancet* published a report about the adverse health effects of climate change. Their conclusion was as jarring as it was straightforward: human health is at the mercy of fossil fuels.

Unfortunately, health remained at the bottom of the priority list at COP27. To be sure, some important health-focused conversations took place at the World Health Organization's side pavilion. These discussions were particularly timely, given the current surge of Covid-19, fueled by the newest Omicron subvariants, in Europe and the United States. But, beyond a blink-and-you-miss-it mention in the preamble, the COP27 declaration makes no substantive mention of the climate-health nexus. It is a glaring omission. The connection between climate and health is deep and multifaceted. Consider, for example, how warming temperatures and unprecedented flooding have encouraged the spread of mosquitoes – carriers of diseases like dengue fever, malaria, and the Zika virus – well beyond their traditional breeding grounds. If nothing is done, Zika will threaten an additional 1.3 billion people by 2050, and dengue fever will affect a whopping 60 percent of the world's population by 2080.

Similarly, climate-driven migration and shrinking animal habitats increase the risk that viruses and bacteria will jump from animal hosts to humans – just as SARS-CoV-2, the virus that causes Covid-19, likely did. This makes another pandemic increasingly likely.

Global warming is also worsening air pollution and, in turn, chronic non-communicable diseases like asthma and chronic obstructive pulmonary disease. Arvind Kumar, who founded the Lung Care Foundation in Delhi, laments that practically everyone in India has the health profile of a smoker, simply because of air pollution. In fact, nearly 1.7 million Indians die every year from its effects. The people most affected by these climate-related health issues have often done the least to create them. Many residents of Bangladesh, Mozambique, and Pakistan do not even own cars. Yet they are suffering from the floods, cyclones, and rising sea levels that have resulted from developed-country emissions.

Fortunately, key lessons from the pandemic response can help us tackle the health challenges that climate change raises. For starters, we need a revolution in data collection and analysis. Global systems to capture and share relevant data progressed significantly during the pandemic, but we are still using only a small share of the information generated. Worse, the data tend to be divided into siloes.

To get a more complete picture of the health effects of climate change, we must integrate clinical, epidemiological, and genomic data from health systems with diverse non-health data, including on weather patterns, wastewater surveillance, consumer behaviour, and even social media and mobility. New open-source platforms like Global.health are an important step in the right direction, but much more must be done.

Another lesson from the pandemic is that, to avoid slipping back into the cycle of panic and neglect, any resilience agenda requires sustainable financing. When Covid-19 emerged, scores of global actors – particularly in the arena of vaccines research – acted with unprecedented speed and coordination.

But while large amounts of funding supported short-term initiatives, not nearly enough investment has been channelled subsequently toward pandemic prevention and preparedness. Likewise, while governments have responded to some of the immediate dramatic effects of climate change, such as natural disasters, interventions to address the climate crisis remain meagre.

As a first step, world leaders should back the Bridgetown Agenda, which seeks to reform global finance for the twenty-first century, including by ensuring that it supports climate action and pandemic prevention. They should also take every opportunity to connect climate and health issues in international forums, including at this month's UN Biodiversity Conference in Montreal.

A final critical lesson from the Covid-19 pandemic is that an effective response depends on community trust and engagement. As with face masks and vaccines, community-based organisations and civil society will play a pivotal role in determining whether there is broad public buy-in for a bold agenda that covers both climate and health.

This will require a comprehensive, policy-shaping discussion that establishes a common language and shared intentions across sectors. Where should we aim to *prevent* the health consequences associated with climate change, and where should we *mitigate* them? Where should we *adapt* to the health effects of a warming planet, and why is an adaptation agenda becoming increasingly urgent?

In October, the UN confirmed that the world is far from meeting the goal, established in the 2015 Paris climate agreement, of limiting global warming to 1.5° Celsius above pre-industrial levels, and we may instead be headed to a catastrophic 2.8°C temperature rise by the end of the century. As the

United Kingdom's COP27 representative Alok Sharma noted after the conference, the 1.5°C goal is now on "life support."

Concerted action must be taken to revive it – and that starts with recognising that climate and health are part of the same conversation. They can and must be tackled together.

***Source: https://www.thedailystar.net/opinion/views/project-syndicate/news/climate-change-making-us-sick-3203976***
***Sat Dec 24, 2022 05:00 PM***
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আমরা এই বইয়ের আলোচনার একেবারে শেষে এসে পৌঁছেছি। এপর্যায়ে আমরা আলোচনা করবো Focus Writing এবং Analytical Writing নিয়ে। একটি কথা বলে দেয়া দরকার যে আমাদের এই বইটি কোনোভাবেই Focus Writing এবং Analytical Writing নিয়ে নয়। আমরা এই পর্যায়ে কেবল এটা দেখাচ্ছি যে এতক্ষণ আপনি যে স্ট্রাকচার শিখেছেন তার প্রয়োগ কীভাবে করতে হয় বিভিন্ন ধরনের লেখালিখিতে।

## FOCUS WRITING

ফোকাস রাইটিং একটি ধরন হলো Descriptive রাইটিং যা আমরা সাধারণভাবে ফোকাস রাইটিং বলে থাকে। আমরা এবার এই বিষয়টি নিয়ে আলোচনা করতে যাচ্ছি। মূলত এই ধরনের লেখালিখিতে একটি নির্দিষ্ট টপিকের উপর লিখতে হয়। আমাদের দেশের বিভিন্ন প্রতিযোগিতামূলক লিখিত পরীক্ষায় আপনি এই ধরনের প্রশ্ন পাবেন। এই ধরনের লেখাতে নির্দিষ্ট কোনো ফরম্যাট নেই কেননা বিভিন্ন ধরণের টপিকের উপর বিভিন্ন রকম স্ট্রাকচার প্রযোজ্য হতে পারে। তবে হ্যাঁ, মতামতে ভিন্নতা থাকতেই পারে। একেবারে বেসিক কিছু বিষয় নিয়ে লক্ষ্য রেখে লিখতে পারলেই হবে। এই লেখায় সাধারণত ৩ টি অংশ থাকে।

01. Introduction
02. Main body
03. Conclusion

এই তিনটি অংশের মধ্যে আপনি চাইলে ২য় অংশে গিয়ে আরো কিছু অংশ নিজে দরকার অনুসারে তৈরি করে নিতে পারেন। তবে এখানে একটি কথা খুব গুরুত্বপূর্ণ, তাহলো, ১ম এবং ৩য় অংশতে তাল বজায় রাখাটা খুব জরুরী। মনে রাখবেন, Introduction হলো একটি আয়নার মতো, যেখানে পরীক্ষক দেখতে পাবেন, আপনি কী কী বিষয় উপস্থাপন করতে যাচ্ছেন, এবং Conclusion এ গিয়ে আপনি যা যা উপস্থাপন করেছেন, তার একটা সারাংশ তুলে ধরবেন। এই বিষয়টি আমরা অনেকেই লক্ষ্য করতেই ভুলে যাই। কিন্তু যেহেতু বিষয়টি জেনে গিয়েছেন, এখন থেকে আশা করি, এই ভুলটি করবেন না।

চলুন, আমরা একটি টপিক নিয়ে লিখতে লিখতে পুরো বিষয়টি বুঝতে চেষ্টা করি।

ধরা, যাক, আপনাকে লিখতে বলা হয়েছে নিচের টপিক টি নিয়ে এবং শব্দ সংখ্যা হতে হবে 350/360 এর বেশি না।

**"Impacts of the Russia-Ukraine War (RUW)"**

দেখুন, এটি এমন একটি টপিক যে আপনি চাইলে ৫০০০ শব্দের আর্টিকেল লিখে ফেলতে পারেন কিন্তু এর সম্পর্ক লিখে শেষ করা যাবে না। তাই এই ধরনের টপিকে লিখার সময় খেয়াল রাখতে হবে আপনার সময়ের সীমাবদ্ধতা কেননা লিখিত পরীক্ষায় আপনাকে নির্দিষ্ট সময়ের মধ্যে লিখে শেষ করতে হবে।

আমরা জানি আমাদের লেখাতে মোট ৩ টি অংশ থাকবে। আমরা প্রথমেই ভেবে নিতে চাই, যা আমরা লেখাতে উপস্থাপন করতে যাচ্ছি। ভেবে নেয়ার এই কাজটি বলা হয়ে থাকে Analysis of the Issue. এই কাজটি করে নিতে পারলে খুব দ্রুত লিখাটা লিখতে পারবেন।

প্রথমে চিন্তা করুন, আপনি কীভাবে বিষয়টিকে তুলে ধরবেন। এই বিষয়টি নানাভাবেই আলোচনা করা যায়। যেমন, কেউ চাইলে বিষয়টি লিখতে গিয়ে মানবতার দিক তুলে ধরতে পারেন, কিংবা এর আর্থিক ক্ষতি, কিংবা সৃষ্ট খাদ্য সংকটসহ নানা আঙ্গিকে আলোচনা করতে পারেন। যেহেতু টপিকে নির্দিষ্ট করে কোনো কিছু বলা হয়নি, তাই আমার মতে এখানে সামগ্রিক আলোচনা করলেই ভালো লাগবে। অর্থাৎ কোনো একটি দিক আলোচনা না করে বিভিন্ন দিক থেকে আলোচনা করা হবে। কিন্তু এক্ষেত্রে সমস্যা হলো কোনো দিন সম্পূর্ণ আলোচনা করা সম্ভব নয় বরং আমাদের সংক্ষিপ্ত আলোচনার দিকে গুরুত্ব দিতে হবে।

আরেকটি বিষয় হলো লেখার মধ্যে একটা বিশ্বাসযোগ্যতা থাকা চাই। আর এই কাজটি করা হয়, মূলত ডাটা, তথ্য, গ্রাফ ইত্যাদির উপস্থাপনার মাধ্যমে। তাই আমাদের প্রথমে এই বিষয়ের উপর কিছু ডাটা নোট করে নিতে হবে। নিচের তথ্যগুলো দেখুন। এগুলো আপনার লেখার মানকে অনেক এগিয়ে নেবে। সবকিছু মাথায় রেখেই লিখতে শুরু করা যাক।

প্রথমেই দেখা যাক, আমরা কী কী লিখবো। আমি যেকোনো লেখার শুরুতে সম্ভব হলে প্রাসঙ্গিকতা বজায় রেখে টপিকের সাথে সম্পর্কিত একটি কোটেশন দিয়ে শুরু করা পছন্দ করি। তাই শুরুতেই একটি কোটেশন নিচ্ছি।

*"After more than a year of fighting, it is clear that neither side in the Russia-Ukraine war can win on the battlefield."*

– Brahma Chellaney (Mar 23, 2023)

এবার একটি Introduction লিখবো যেখানে আমি বলতে চাচ্ছি যে এই যুদ্ধের ফলে আসলেই ক্ষতি হচ্ছে। মাথায় রাখা উচিত, আমাদের লেখা হবে এই যুদ্ধের প্রভাব বা ফলাফল নিয়ে। তাই শুরুটা এমন হতে পারে। Ramifications of RUW – as estimated by veteran experts – are now conspicuous, resulting in a tremendous global geo-political crisis, skyrocketing fuel prices, and destroying the stability of many developing nations including Bangladesh.

**A timeline of the Russia-Ukraine war**

**Feb 24, 2022:** Putin launches the operation.
**March 2022:** World food prices reach a record high.
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এবার আমরা এই যুদ্ধ সম্পর্কিত একটি Timeline দেয়ার চেষ্টা করবো।

The existing hostility between the two nations dates back many years. But, the situation deteriorated as Ukraine decided to join NATO, a fact that is a direct threat to the sovereignty of Russia. So, ignoring international sanctions, Russia invaded Ukraine on 24th Feb, 2022, resulting in the biggest refugee crisis (about 7.9 million) after the second world war. The

humanitarian crisis was impending when Russia annexed Crimea in 2014.

এরপর আমরা যাবো বিভিন্ন পক্ষ কিভাবে এতে জড়িয়ে পরে তা নিয়ে একটি সংক্ষিপ্ত উপস্থাপনায়।

As Ukraine is buttressed by its allies including the USA, Germany, the UK, etc – it has been receiving many advanced weapons including Leopard 2 and Abrams tanks, HIMARS Missile technology and so on. And, Russia is also showing its capacity and has already annexed many territories of Ukraine including Donetsk and Luhansk. Both countries are two biggest suppliers of food. So, the costs of food have been soaring in other countries as well.

এরপর আমাদের লক্ষ্য হতে পারে এই যুদ্ধের পরিণতি নিয়ে কিছু বিষয় উল্লেখ করা।

Ramifications are shown in the following.

1. Provoking the possibility of nuclear war as the president of Ukraine is now demanding F-16 fighter jet.
2. **41%**[1] of gas and about 25% of oil used in the EU comes from Russia. Inflation has become rampant and recession is knocking, as per experts' opinion. For example, Germany has been witnessing 8.7% inflation, the highest since 1990 and the UK's inflation is 11.1%, the highest of the last 41 years.

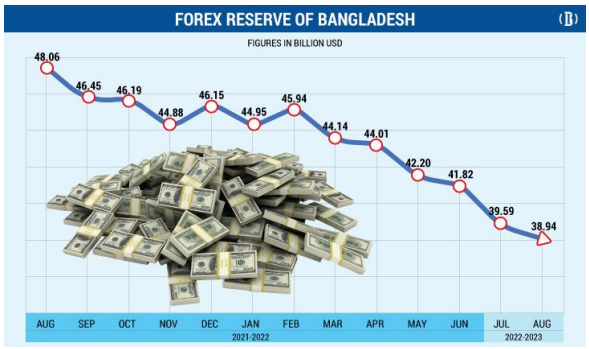



Figure 01

3. Bangladesh exported $550 million in FY 2021 in Russia, which is declining and import costs of wheat and maize are surging.
4. Macroeconomic stability is being destroyed and the dollar price is rising (TK.86 in 2022 and 108 in 2023; at kerb market, the rate was even higher), a fact resulting in an expedited decline in foreign reserves (shown in figure 01; **$21.15b**[2] currently) and skyrocketing deficit in the balance of payment.
5. Due to excessive inflationary pressure, central authorities are being forced to increase policy rates. Recently, Bangladesh Bank has increased it by 75 points and new policy rate is **7.25%**[3]**.**
6. As global economy was recovering from the fallout caused by COVID-19, the emergence of RUW has devasted its possibility, a fact shown in the projected growth of global economy estimated by IMF and ADB.

সর্বশেষ পর্যায়ে আমরা একটি Conclusion দিয়ে লেখাটি শেষ করবো।

Finally, protracted war never brings forth peace. Peace derives from mutual trust, cooperation, ethics, diplomatic ties, etc. UN can perform a significant role in this regard as is performed by Turkey so that the world experiences a place free from animosity, hostility, inflation, escalated tension, unprecedented military practice, etc.

এবারে 41%[1], $21.15b[2], 7.25%[3] এদের দিকে লক্ষ্য করুন। আমরা এখানে ১, ২ এবং ৩ এর দ্বারা এটা বুঝাতে চাচ্ছি যে এখানে কিছু তথ্যগুলো সঠিক কিনা তা যাচাই এর জন্য আমরা রেফারেন্স দিয়েছি। এইভাবে প্রতিটি লেখায় কিছুক্ষেত্রে সম্ভব হলে রেফারেন্স করবেন।

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***Reference:***

1. ***CNBC, Date: Feb 24, 2022***
2. ***The Daily Star, Date: Sep 28, 2023***
3. ***The Business Standard, Date: Oct 04, 2023***

যেহেতু রিজার্ভ আমাদের দেশের একটি গুরুত্বপূর্ণ ইস্যু তাই এই সম্পর্কে আপনি একটি গ্রাফ নিয়ে আসতে পারেন। এবার দেখুন, আমাদের লেখাটির বর্তমান অবস্থা নিচের মতো।

## Impacts of the Russia-Ukraine War (RUW)

*"After more than a year of fighting, it is clear that neither side in the Russia-Ukraine war can win on the battlefield."*
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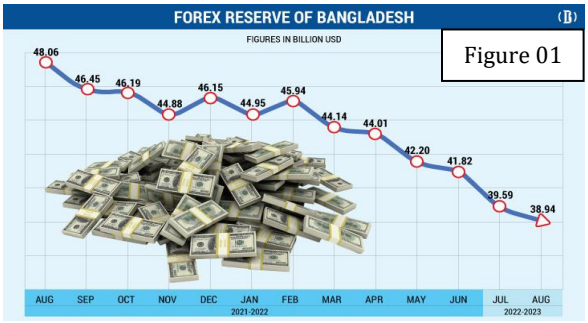


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6. As global economy was recovering from the fallout caused by COVID-19, the emergence of RUW has devasted its possibility, a fact shown in the projected growth of global economy estimated by IMF and ADB.

Only international condemnation and the raft of sanctions will not suffice. International allies should adopt pragmatic policies to quell conflicts. NATO should abandon its expansion policy toward Russia. In addition to this, superpowers including Russia, China and India should abandon their policy of creating hegemony over other countries.

Finally, protracted war never brings forth peace. Peace derives from mutual trust, cooperation, ethics, diplomatic ties, etc. UN can perform a significant role in this regard as is performed by Turkey so that the world experiences a place free from animosity, hostility, inflation, escalated tension, unprecedented military practice, etc.

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***Reference:***

7. ***CNBC, Date: Feb 24, 2022***
8. ***The Daily Star, Date: Sep 28, 2023***
9. ***The Business Standard, Date: Oct 04, 2023***

এবার এখানে আমরা কিছু আর্টিকেল দিয়েছি, যেগুলো দেখার অনুরোধ রইলো। এগুলো কোনো সোর্স থেকে কপি করা নয়। তবে এই আর্টিকেলগুলোতে আমাদের মূল লক্ষ্য ছিলো আপনাকে এতোক্ষণ যা শিখানো হয়েছে বাক্যের গঠন নিয়ে, তার একটি প্রয়োগ দেখানো। অবশ্যই যেকোনো আর্টিকেল লিখার সময় কোটেশন, যথাযথ রেফারেন্স, গ্রাফ, চার্ট, ডাটা, এসব ব্যবহার করতে হবে।

## Way to Modern Education

The idea of the true purpose of education is very debatable. Everyone has a superficial understanding of what it is, and no one can really explain it in an absolute way. The main idea was to teach people how to survive. According to history, people in large numbers used to learn war tactics, hunting, and anything that was important for survival. As civilizations grew, different needs erupted, as well as professions to meet those needs. Certain people mastered certain professions in order to earn a living. Then, learning those specific skills was called education, and only a few could read and write. There were few formal institutions but only for the rich, the poor had no place in there. A thirst for knowledge was present every decade. Those who had an unquenchable thirst for knowledge learned on their own and discovered miracles. Soon, people began to understand that proper use of knowledge can make life easier, and it is vital besides learning warfare. Acquiring that knowledge was also counted as education. Thus, a new revolution based on knowledge and science started.

In today's world, the approach towards education and the education system itself varies from country to country and even person to person, depending on the country's socioeconomic structure. In most countries, primary education is a must for both men and women. In developed countries, only youngsters who are good at studies tend to go for higher qualifications. The scenario is quite different in developing and third-world countries. Here, the certification of completing formal education is more important than the education itself because without a certificate, they would not get a job, and without a job, they would not be able to earn a living. A Student's mindset and approach toward learning have a lot to do with the impact it will have on his life.

The modern education system values examination results more than knowledge, which provokes students to gain an outward understanding of their respective subjects so that they can pass their examinations. These students manage to pass but fail to demonstrate their knowledge of solving real-life problems. For a country to develop, its people should be able to solve every challenge that erupts. Depending on foreign aid to solve a respective nation's situation would not help in the long run. A student's sole purpose is to educate himself so that he can contribute to his country's future.

A Society that thrives to have comfort and food will never act upon the true purpose of education because, like in ancient times, survival gets the utmost priority. A country's education system focuses on creating assets for itself. The better their education system is, the more capable delegates will be seen to represent a country, which will benefit a country's future.

# The Emerging Economy of Bangladesh

Bangladesh, a country of economic ingenuity and resilience, is nurturing the buds of its potential into blossoms of prosperity amidst global financial instability. With GDP enabling a robust growth rate of approximately 6%, a tapestry of transformation unfolds across its economy. Through the development of various industries such as ready-made garments, agriculture, pharmaceuticals, ICT, leather, and shipbuilding, the fabric of its economic story is woven with diverse threads of innovation and productivity. Tailored with the precision of strategic reforms and investments, the government's role exemplifies the supportive structure upon which the probability of economic independence heavily relies.

As of 2022-23, the labor force of Bangladesh, an essential component of the country's economic machinery, encompasses a dynamic 87 million individuals, each contributing uniquely to various sectors with dedication and expertise. Within this diverse economic activity, Small and Medium-sized Enterprises (SMEs) hold a pivotal position, representing not just business entities but the embodiment of the nation's entrepreneurial spirit. These SMEs, which constitute 90% of all businesses, are central pillars supporting the architecture of the economy, providing employment avenues that sustain approximately 80% of the workforce. In a realm where adaptability is a crucial asset, SMEs in Bangladesh flourish, continuously evolving and aligning themselves with market demands and global trends. Their capacity to innovate and adapt is not merely a characteristic but a vital strategy that fuels their sustainability and growth. The influence that SMEs wield is reflective of their intrinsic role in the nation's journey towards economic proliferation and stability.

The rivers of its economy also cascade through regular challenges, such as an inflation rate of 8.9% and a trade deficit of USD 15 billion. Navigating these economic hurdles requires implications of strategic policies, fortified resilience, and an oar of adaptability. Poverty, the shadow that often dims the landscapes of potential, covers 20% of the nation's terrain. Inequality, too, is a lingering cloud with a Gini coefficient of 0.48 in 2022. Yet, the climate of Bangladesh's economy is also illuminated by the hope of opportunities, where sectors like the ready-made garment industry demonstrate global competitiveness and excellence, contributing a vast expanse of over 20% to the GDP and cradling 80% of exports in its embrace.

Urbanization, the evolving topography of the nation, projects an image where cities will burgeon, expected to double their embrace by 2050. In this geographical transformation, cities emerge as dynamic hubs where opportunities flourish, innovation navigates the streets, and economic vibrancy paints the urban landscapes with diverse hues of possibility. The digital winds also sweep across Bangladesh's economic skies, heralding an ambiance conducive to technological growth and digital transformation. Infrastructure, the bones upon which the body of the economy stands, is strengthened by significant investments, enhancing connectivity, and fortifying the structural integrity of economic pathways.

Bangladesh is making notable progress in its economic journey. While there are challenges like poverty and trade deficits, the strong growth in sectors such as garments, technology, and SMEs shows promise. The country's infrastructure and digital initiatives investments highlight its commitment to development. The mix of successes and hurdles paints a picture of a nation actively working towards a better future, setting a notable example for emerging economies globally.

# First Trip to A New Place

If someone asks me why I love traveling so much, my answer, enriched by the wisdom of a famous saying—the world is a book, and those who do not travel read only the first page, carries the essence of curiosity and wonder that initially inspired me to embark on various journeys. One such golden opportunity, which was gracefully offered by my brother who was keen on exploring the unveiled paths of Nafakhum, Bandarban, knocked on my door, bringing with it the promises of an exotic adventure. Instantly, with an eagerness that consumed all hesitation, I embraced the opportunity, a chance that seemed filled with the promise of experiencing the local culture of the ethnicities and a plethora of unforeseen revelations.

On the awaited day of departure, despite being shrouded in the enthusiasm of what lay ahead, we encountered our first hurdle: our bus, delayed by an unfortunate hour, which resulted in a two-hour late arrival at Thanchi. Our first interaction with the food was at a local restaurant, a place where the aroma of ethnic cuisines filled the air and where we indulged in a delightful breakfast, an experience that was untouched by the realization of the adversities that awaited us. Following this, in the rugged, yet comforting embrace of jeep cars, colloquially known as “Chander Gari,” we set forth towards Thanchi, accompanied by the soothing mountain breezes that whispered the tales of the terrains.

During the subsequent four days, a group of thirty individuals, travel freaks unknown to one another, found themselves intoxicated by the shared experiences, where moments were embroidered with songs, meals, gossip, and the crafting of memories that would be cherished beyond the journey. Surrounded by the mesmerizing beauty of nature, my senses were so deeply engrossed that I did not even notice the cheerfulness of the team members upon arriving at Thanchi.

Thanchi, despite its embrace by remoteness, proudly hosted elements essential to a modern lifestyle—a connection to the digital world, electricity, institutions symbolizing education and healthcare, and a diversity of other conveniences, each adding a layer of comfort to our experience.

Our journey witnessed the canvas of nature’s artwork, where the Sangu River, flowing with a gentle, yet persistent grace, adorned the mountains, and the soft kisses of the morning sunlight enhanced its ethereal beauty. The paths, each winding mysteriously towards destinations like Kumari Jharna—a hidden spring—and Langlok, though strewn with challenges, became the thresholds of breathtaking sights such as mighty waterfalls whose grandeur was like a symphony of nature’s most splendid tunes. These paths, some adorned with the tranquility of solitude, and others echoing with the vibrant sounds of gushing waters, became the landscapes where tiredness was overshadowed by awe and wonder.

Each step of our journey, marked by the elements of surprise and exploration, seemed like a chapter of a captivating tale. From the rigorous trekking that tested our endurance to the spontaneous joy experienced in the clear waters of Khum, each moment was a blend of various shades of adventure. In the embrace of these varied experiences, from the fatigue gently soothed by brief moments of rest to the reinvigoration found in the beauty of places like Nafakhum Para, our spirits were continually refueled, enabling us to march ahead with renewed energy and enthusiasm.

In the realms of Nafakhum and Jinnah Para, where nature unveiled its mighty as well as gentle facets, our journey was a pendulum swinging between periods of strenuous treks and the serenity found in the picturesque surroundings. Encounters such as the crossing of the Sangu River, where the currents were fierce contenders and where collective effort became our beacon of safety, showcased the symphony of challenge and triumph. Guided by the tender hands of divine mercy, our journey, despite its array of trials and tribulations, unfolded into a tale of memorable experiences and learnings, each thread weaving the stories of our exploration, survival, and the delightful discoveries made in the heart of nature’s magnificent theater.

## The Dhaka Metro Rail

The Dhaka Metro Rail, an innovative urban transportation project, represents a paradigm shift in addressing the chronic transportation dilemmas that plague Dhaka, the bustling capital of Bangladesh. Managed by the Dhaka Mass Transit Company Limited (DMTCL), this extensive transit system, which has been conceptualized to span over 130 kilometers by 2030, promises to provide residents with a rapid and efficient mode of transport. Its funding, a collaboration that involves prominent international and national entities such as the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA), the Asian Development Bank (ADB), the European Investment Bank (EIB), and the Government of Bangladesh, is a testament to the strategic importance of this project.

MRT Line 6, which stretches from Uttara North to Kamalapur, has already made its mark, becoming operational in December 2022. Comprising 16 meticulously designed stations that not only facilitate movement but also celebrate the rich cultural heritage of Bangladesh, this line is a harbinger of the transformation the metro promises to bring. Subsequent lines, such as MRT Line 1, are under construction, while others like MRT Line 5, both its Northern and Southern Routes, and MRT Line 2 and 4, are still in the planning stages. The rolling stock for these lines, which includes sophisticated six-car trains, promises a transit experience that is both swift, with speeds reaching up to 100 km/h, and comfortable.

From an economic perspective, the metro rail represents a significant financial commitment, with the construction costs for just MRT Line 6 and MRT Line 1 amounting to Tk 33,472 crore (US$ 3.9 billion) and Tk 52,561 crore (US$ 6.1 billion), respectively. Yet, when one considers the benefits it offers, which range from the tangible, such as a 50-60% reduction in travel time and a 20-30% decrease in traffic congestion, to the more intangible, like improved air quality, the justification for this investment becomes more apparent. Besides, it is hoped that the introduction of this modern transportation system, whose fares are strategically priced between Tk 20 (US$ 0.23) and Tk 100 (US$ 1.15) to ensure accessibility for all, will bolster economic growth by creating jobs and fostering urban development.

While the metro rail, in the eyes of many, emerges as a beacon of hope, it has not been without its critics. Some detractors, scrutinizing Bangladesh's economic fabric, question the feasibility of such a grand endeavor. They posit that perhaps other solutions, such as enhancing the existing road infrastructure or bolstering the bus transit system, might have been more pragmatic. However, it is undeniable that the metro rail offers a more long-term and comprehensive solution to Dhaka's transportation challenges.

In conclusion, the Dhaka Metro Rail is not merely a transportation project; it is emblematic of a nation's aspirations. As Dhaka evolves and its demands become more complex, solutions like the metro rail, which marry functionality with vision, become imperative. It remains to be seen how this project will unfold in the coming years, but its current trajectory suggests that Dhaka is on the cusp of a transformative urban revolution.

## My Most Precious Value

In the vast realm of human virtues, loyalty, an attribute often mentioned but seldom deeply pondered, shines uniquely for me. Among the myriad values one could hold dear, one might wonder why loyalty stands as my most treasured. The reason, which stems from both personal experiences and reflections, is multifaceted. Loyalty, which can be directed towards a person, belief, or cause, represents an unwavering allegiance even when the road becomes challenging. Rooted in honesty and integrity, loyalty fosters trust, camaraderie, and lasting bonds, attributes I deem paramount in both personal and broader societal contexts.

Growing up, I was often caught in the whirlwind of dilemmas concerning loyalty. The conundrum, which arises in the minds of many, was apparent: Why forgo immediate pleasures or gains for the sake of an abstract principle like loyalty? However, as I navigated life's labyrinth, experiences, which often serve as the best mentors, elucidated this virtue's unparalleled worth. During phases of adversity, when the world seemed shrouded in shadows, I encountered individuals whose fidelity never wavered. Their actions, which were shaped by an innate sense of loyalty rather than a sense of obligation, became my guiding star. Such acts, done without expecting returns and often at personal cost, illuminated for me the inherent value of loyalty. It was not just a word but a binding force, more potent than any external challenge, that could rally spirits and muster hope even in dire situations.

While epics and grand tales narrate stories of loyalty in monumental proportions, it's the subtleties and everyday manifestations of this virtue that further reinforce its significance to me. These gestures, whether it's a friend standing by another during trying times or an individual upholding a belief in the face of opposition, might seem inconsequential. However, it's in these moments, often overlooked in the grand narrative of life, where the true essence of loyalty shines. The depth of this virtue, which often goes unnoticed in daily interactions, is profound. In its simplicity lies its strength, and in its quietude, its voice resonates loudly, echoing the sentiment that loyalty is not just a feeling but a way of life.

Loyalty's real test, which is invariably the most illuminating, arises during challenging times. In situations where societal norms pressure one to conform or when personal gains tempt one to waver, loyalty stands as the bulwark against such forces. Such instances, which compel individuals to make choices that reflect their core values, underscore loyalty's unmatched worth. It acts as a compass, guiding one towards paths that honor integrity, trust, and genuine connection.

Among the diverse values that one could cherish, loyalty holds a special place for me due to its unparalleled ability to forge deep connections, uplift spirits, and act as a guiding principle in life. It's a virtue that transcends momentary gains, upholds integrity, and stands resilient in the face of challenges. More than any material possession or fleeting emotion, loyalty, for me, embodies the essence of genuine human connection and remains a beacon of hope in an ever-changing world.

## The Tourism Sector of Bangladesh

Tourism in Bangladesh, which embodies a vibrant array of cultural and natural attractions, plays a pivotal role in the socio-economic development of the country. The sector, where the interplay of various activities captivates the imagination of global travelers, contributed an impressive 4.4% to the nation's GDP in 2022. Strengthened by the government's strategic initiatives, such as the development of new hotels, resorts, and airports, Bangladesh's tourism sector, despite its humble beginnings, has catapulted itself into a significant avenue for economic diversification and foreign exchange earnings since the country's independence.

Amongst the varied tourist attractions, Sundarbans reigns with its majestic presence, renowned as the world's largest mangrove forest and a proud UNESCO World Heritage Site. This natural marvel is not only a habitat for the majestic Royal Bengal Tiger but also a biodiversity hotspot that captivates nature enthusiasts globally. Cox's Bazar is another jewel in Bangladesh's tourist crown, captivating with the world's longest natural sea beach, where the waves gently kiss the shores, offering an unforgettable coastal beauty. The Chittagong Hill Tracts further enrich the tourist experience with its undulating hills, lush forests, and woven tapestry of tribal cultures, adding vivid colors to the visitor's journey.

In the heart of Bangladesh's cultural treasures lies Bagerhat's Shat Gambuj Mosque, an architectural masterpiece and a UNESCO World Heritage Site, which whispers historical and religious tales through its ancient walls. Paharpur and Moinamoti, holding the archaeological brilliance in their realms, showcase the rich Buddhist heritage, with the ruins of ancient monasteries that serve as windows to the past. Sylhet, a serene symphony of tea gardens, rolling hills, and rhythmic waterfalls, holds a mesmerizing aura that soothes the souls of its visitors, while places like Peyara Bagan offer a unique experience, with its enchanting display of myriad flower species, allowing one to stroll through the vivid blossoms of nature's beauty.

Within the tourism ecosystem, an array of facilities and services vital for enhancing the visitor experience and whose enhancement is a testimony to the government's commitment has seen a tremendous upswing. The structural and promotional reforms, fostered by initiatives such as the "Bangladesh Tourism Master Plan 2021-2030", are instrumental in harnessing the sector's potential. It's in this nurturing environment that Bangladesh saw the arrival of 1.6 million foreign tourists, a testament to its growing appeal as a favored tourism destination.

In a global context, where comparison acts as a mirror, Bangladesh can reflect upon the accomplishments of its economic peers. Countries like Vietnam and Indonesia, which have woven the threads of innovation and strategic promotion into the fabric of their tourism sectors, stand as inspiring chapters of success. They have accomplished remarkable tourism achievements through enhanced infrastructural frameworks and captivating marketing tactics, which have flourished their global footprints in the tourism genre.

Employment generation is an intrinsic merit of this sector. Jobs created across various levels and domains within the tourism value chain underscore the sector's contribution to livelihood enhancement and poverty alleviation. In essence, the sector acts as a significant employer, facilitating economic opportunities and empowerment in various communities and regions within the country.

Despite its accomplishments, the sector is not without its challenges. A nuanced approach to addressing issues such as improving service quality, enhancing global perception, and leveraging international marketing is indispensable for sustained growth. These factors, integral to elevating the tourist experience, are essential ingredients in the recipe for tourism success, and they echo the strategic priorities emphasized by thriving global tourism destinations.

Bangladesh's tourism sector, adorned with natural beauty and cultural heritage and nurtured by strategic investments and initiatives, stands as a vibrant contributor to the country's socio-economic landscape. Its journey, marked by evolution, resilience, and potential, holds the promise of an even brighter, more prosperous future in the global tourism arena.

## Climate Change Adversities of Bangladesh

Bangladesh, nestled in the vulnerable embrace of climate uncertainties, stands as a poignant testament to the ravaging effects of climate change, bearing the tumultuous brunt of natural disasters that, catalyzed by climate abnormalities, wreak havoc across the nation. Since 2009, a commendable investment exceeding $1 billion has been infused into climate change adaptation and mitigation measures by Bangladesh, a strategic maneuver underscored by the government's commitment to fortify the nation against the relentless onslaught of environmental adversities. Augmenting this domestic financial commitment, the international realm has manifested its supportive presence, bestowing upon Bangladesh foreign grants that soar over $3 billion, an economic reservoir dedicated to orchestrating diverse climate change projects.

The nation grapples with a multitude of climate disasters, such as cyclones, floods, and droughts, incidents that severely compromise its socioeconomic stability. Cyclones, in particular, are prevalent, with Cyclone Amphan in 2020 causing significant damage, which emphasized the country's vulnerability to climate anomalies. Floods, another recurrent issue, have resulted in extensive damage to the nation's agriculture and infrastructure, as was seen in 2021. Additionally, the occurrence of droughts, an increasing concern due to climate change, has led to significant agricultural losses, particularly noticeable in 2022.

Climate-related calamities profoundly shape Bangladesh's societal and economic realms, incurring losses that transcend life and property and ripple into broader economic upheavals. Such losses, which manifest in the ravaging of crucial infrastructure and agriculture sectors - integral components of the nation's prosperity and survival - perpetuate cycles of poverty and inequality. This amplifies the country's susceptibility to environmental disruptions, a reality embedded in the complexities of escalating adversities. Bangladesh's government has unveiled strategic mechanisms to nurture resilience against the tempestuous embrace of climate adversities. Within this realm of strategies, emphasis has been placed on amplifying disaster readiness, championing agricultural practices imbued with climate sensitivity, and cultivating infrastructure possessing the tenacity to endure climatic hostilities.

The government of Bangladesh has instituted essential safety nets, a strategy primarily aimed at supporting the most vulnerable populations who are heavily impacted by climate disasters. These support systems, crucial in offering necessary assistance, ensure these populations are protected and supported during adversities. Alongside this, a focused effort has been placed on mitigating the impacts of climate change. Essential to this strategy are several key initiatives that encompass promoting renewable energy, improving energy efficiency, and ensuring the preservation and sustainability of forests.

This strategic approach, which is deeply rooted in a commitment to reduce the impacts of climate change, also aligns with the broader global goals and objectives of sustainability. Therefore, through these strategic initiatives and actions, Bangladesh is showcasing a robust commitment to implementing effective strategies and actions that are crucial in addressing the significant challenges posed by climate change.

Bangladesh has exhibited considerable dedication to addressing the various challenges of climate change. Through substantial investments, the reception of international grants, and the implementation of comprehensive adaptation and mitigation strategies, the country strives to enhance its resilience against climatic uncertainties, aspiring to safeguard its future from the adverse impacts of climate change. By doing so, Bangladesh's strategies and experiences serve as a reference, offering insights that may be beneficial for other nations grappling with similar climatic adversities.

## The Russia-Ukraine War

The Russia-Ukraine war, which began in February 2022, has emerged as the most significant military confrontation in Europe since the cataclysmic events of World War II. This conflict, rooted in the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991—a pivotal event after which Ukraine achieved its much-desired independence—has seen persistent efforts by Russia to assert its dominion, viewing Ukraine as ensconced within its sphere of influence. This perspective led Russia, in 2014, to annex the Crimean Peninsula, an act that heralded its support for pro-Russian separatists in the eastern parts of Ukraine. The situation deteriorated markedly in February 2022 when Russia initiated a full-scale assault on Ukraine, which resulted in an alarming humanitarian crisis marked by mass displacement, affecting millions, and the upheaval of the global economic order, particularly in the form of surging energy prices and disrupted supply chains.

The war, intricate in its dynamics and still in progress, eludes facile explanations. Multiple perspectives pervade discourses on the conflict, each shedding light on its different facets, although none can be deemed exhaustive or definitive. Several salient factors, nonetheless, have been instrumental in shaping the trajectory of this war. The expansion of NATO, established in 1949 as a bulwark against the might of the Soviet Union, has been a significant irritant for Russia. Post the Soviet collapse, NATO's eastward outreach, encompassing erstwhile Soviet territories, was perceived by Russia as a strategic encroachment. Moreover, the pro-Russian uprising in Ukraine in 2014 exacerbated tensions, as did the unfulfilled promises of the Minsk agreements signed in 2015, intended to placate the situation in eastern Ukraine. Observers also point to the menacing buildup of Russian military forces along Ukraine's frontiers in the prelude to the 2022 invasion as a stark indicator of the impending onslaught.

In the current scenario, despite its territorial inroads in Ukraine's southern and eastern regions, Russia finds itself enmeshed in a war of attrition, unable to clinch a decisive victory. Ukraine's resilient defense has transformed the conflict into a protracted and harrowing engagement. Recently, skirmishes have flared up anew in the Donbas zone, yet a decisive shift in the balance of power remains elusive, even as the war trudges into its eighth month. This prolonged strife has exacted a grievous toll on Ukraine, manifesting in the extensive human displacement, with casualties running into thousands. Besides, the world economy reels under its ramifications, such as mounting energy costs and fractured supply lines.

International voices have been vociferous in denouncing Russia's aggressive maneuvers, translating their censure into punitive sanctions. However, despite their intent, these measures have not been potent enough to sway Russia's stance, underscoring the profound challenge the Russia-Ukraine war presents. As this saga unfolds, its repercussions, both immediate and long-term, are poised to reverberate across Europe and, indeed, the world at large.

## Renewable Energy

Renewable energy has been traversing a transformative journey, emerging as a pivotal player in the global energy theatre. A testament to this is the remarkable escalation in renewable energy capacity, which, in 2022, catapulted to a groundbreaking 295 gigawatts (GW), reflecting an 8% augmentation from the preceding year. Such an enhancement is not merely a numerical increment; instead, it carries the palpable potential of shaping a future that basks in the brilliance of clean and sustainable energy sources, as evidenced by solar and wind power collectively commandeering over 80% of all fresh renewable energy capacity installations in the same year.

Adorned with the mantle of affordability, renewable energy, especially in its solar and wind manifestations, has witnessed a dramatic cost decline, rendering these sources increasingly competitive contenders against the traditional bastions of fossil fuels. This transition, marked by cost-effectiveness, has been a cornerstone in the proliferation of renewable energy, steering it towards accounting for a formidable 38% of global electricity generation in 2022, with projections soaring as high as 70% by the milestone year 2050.

What unfolds alongside this growth trajectory is a tapestry of benefits that span multiple dimensions. Jobs burgeon within the renewable energy sector, which currently embraces over 12 million individuals in a global embrace of employment opportunities. Beyond the confines of economic prosperity, renewable energy also unfolds as a harbinger of environmental rejuvenation, instrumental in mitigating greenhouse gas emissions by averting the release of over two billion tonnes of carbon dioxide in 2022.

Embedded within the broader spectrum of renewable energy are specialized domains that have been flowering with innovations and prospects. Offshore wind power, for instance, heralds a new era of possibilities caressed by the winds of cost-competitiveness and promise. Parallelly, the emergence of green hydrogen, nurtured by the womb of renewable energy, radiates potential for decarbonizing a myriad of sectors, including the pivotal realms of transportation and steelmaking. In the shadows of these advancements lurks the increasingly potent phenomenon of battery storage, which, fortified by enhanced affordability and efficacy, is burgeoning as an integral protagonist in harmonizing the integration of renewable energy into the cohesive grid of consumption and utility.

The decision-making dilemma, wherein countries oscillate between the scopes of renewable energy and the establishment of coal facilities, is a complex arena marked by multifarious considerations. At one end of the spectrum, we witness a resolute march towards renewable energy, fueled by motivations ranging from alleviating greenhouse gas emissions and enhancing air quality to recalibrating energy costs and the genesis of employment avenues. Contrasting this momentum is a persistent inclination towards coal facilities, driven by imperatives such as the provision of steadfast baseload power, the satiation of escalating energy appetites, and the safeguarding of employment landscapes within the coal industry.

The horizon of renewable energy is ablaze with the luminosity of multifaceted potentials and promises. Dominated by an aura of continuous evolution and enhancement, the sector is enriched by a confluence of technological advancements, economic considerations, and environmental imperatives, each weaving into the intricate fabric of a sustainable and resplendent energy future.

## The Global Pandemic

The COVID-19 pandemic, an unparalleled global catastrophe, was first brought to the world's attention in Wuhan, China, where, in December 2019, the Wuhan Municipal Health Commission announced a cluster of 27 pneumonia cases of an unknown origin, all of which were associated with a seafood market in the city, a market that was subsequently shut down. Not long after, on January 7, 2020, Chinese scientists identified the cause: a novel coronavirus, designated SARS-CoV-2, which resulted in the disease named COVID-19. With the first fatality reported on January 20, the virus's rapid transmission, even beyond Chinese borders, prompted the World Health Organization (WHO) to declare a public health emergency of international concern on January 30, and by March 11, the crisis was elevated to a pandemic. At that juncture, SARS-CoV-2 had permeated over 100 countries and afflicted more than 100,000 individuals.

It's almost inconceivable that, as of August 4, 2023, there have been over 580 million confirmed COVID-19 cases and upwards of 6 million deaths. Apart from the profound human loss, the pandemic has exerted immense pressure on the global economy, compelling many businesses to either curtail operations or close entirely, a situation that engendered extensive job losses and economic instability. These economic repercussions resonated deeply in countries like Bangladesh, where the pandemic strained an already fragile healthcare system and upended its predominantly export-driven economy. Educational institutions shuttered, thrusting students and educators into the uncharted territories of online learning. Work paradigms shifted too; numerous individuals began telecommuting, and businesses had to rapidly adapt to a digital-first approach, with start-ups in Bangladesh being significantly impacted. Although some managed to pivot and capitalize on emerging opportunities, others grappled with the challenges of limited resources and disrupted supply chains.

However, amidst the pervasive gloom, rays of optimism shone through. The pandemic, though brutal, sparked certain positive changes. Across the world, including in Bangladesh, there has been an accelerated adoption of groundbreaking technologies, such as telemedicine, underscoring the resilience and adaptability of societies. The pandemic has also renewed our collective appreciation for essential workers and fostered a heightened sense of community, wherein individuals rallied to aid one another in unprecedented times. In response to the havoc, the Bangladeshi government bolstered its healthcare investment, erecting new medical facilities and recruiting additional healthcare professionals. Furthermore, financial relief measures were introduced to alleviate the burdens of those most affected, and public health awareness campaigns emphasizing mask-wearing, hand hygiene, and social distancing took precedence.

The present-day ramifications of the pandemic are evident in our modified lifestyles, shaped by both the traumas of the past and the ongoing vigilance against the virus. With over 60% of the global populace fully vaccinated, a decline in daily case numbers and fatalities is heartening. This decline, a testament to the efficacy of vaccines, coupled with the development of potent treatments and rigorous public health strategies, is indicative of the progress made. Nevertheless, the presence of viral variants necessitates continuous caution.

The COVID-19 pandemic, which commenced under somewhat nebulous circumstances in a market in Wuhan, has metamorphosed our world in multifaceted ways. Its impacts, both devastating and enlightening, serve as a poignant reminder of the vulnerabilities and strengths intrinsic to the human condition.

## ANALYTICAL WRITING ANALYSIS

এবার আমরা রাইটিং এর সবচেয়ে মজার একটি বিষয় নিয়ে কথা বলতে যাচ্ছি। এটি হবে Analytical Writing Analysis এর উপর। মূলত এটি আমাদের দেশে খুব একটা প্রয়োজন না হলেও বর্তমানে এই রকম প্রশ্ন দেখা যাচ্ছে। কিন্তু GMAT এ এর প্রয়োজন আছে।

মূলত এই ধরণের রাইটিং হলো আপনার বুদ্ধির খেলা। যতই বিশ্লেষণ করতে পারবেন, ততই ভালো করবেন এই সেকশনে। প্রথমে একটি টপিক নেয়া যাক। নিচের প্রশ্নটি এসেছিলো ২০২১ সালে অনুষ্ঠিত সহকারী পরিচালক, বাংলাদেশ ব্যাংক এর লিখিত পরীক্ষায়।

The environment problems facing today's world are so great that there is little ordinary people can do to improve the situation. Government and large companies should be responsible for reducing the amount of damage being done to the environment.
To what extent do you agree or disagree with this statement. Give reasons for your answer and include any relevant examples from your own knowledge or experience.

আমরা অনেক সময় এই ধরণের প্রশ্ন পেতে পারি লিখিত পরীক্ষাগুলোতে। মূলত এই ধরণের প্রশ্নের কাঠামোতে তিনটি অংশ থাকে। দুইটি অংশ প্রশ্নে দেয়া থাকে এবং অন্যটি লুকায়িত থাকে, যা আপনাকে বুঝে নিতে হবে। অংশ তিনটির নামঃ

1. Given fact.
2. Assumption.
3. Conclusion.

এখানে Given fact: The environment problems facing today's world are so great that there is little ordinary people can do to improve the situation. অর্থাৎ, environment problems এতো বৃহৎ যে সাধারণ মানুষ এই অবস্থার বা এই সমস্যা নিরসনে খুব একটা কার্যকরী ভূমিকা রাখতে পারে না।

অন্যদিকে Conclusion: Government and large companies should be responsible for reducing the amount of damage being done to the environment. অর্থাৎ, Government and large companies গুলোকেই সমস্যা নিরসনে এগিয়ে আসতে হবে।

তাহলে এবার বলুন, Assumption টা কী এখানে? মূলত এই অংশটি প্রশ্নে সরাসরি বলা থাকে না। এটা বুঝার জন্য আমরা একটি গল্প করি, চলুন।

রাস্তা দিয়ে ৩ বন্ধু হেটে যাচ্ছিল। সামনে কিছুক্ষন পর তারা দেখলো, কিছুটা জায়গা গর্ত হয়ে আছে। সেটা দেখে এক বন্ধু বলল, নেতারা যে কি করে। এরা কি রাস্তাঘাটের প্রতি একটু খেয়াল করে না? কিন্তু দ্বিতীয় বন্ধু বলল, আরে না বন্ধু, এখানকার নেতারা ভালো। কিন্তু, জনগণ নিজেরাই রাস্তাঘাট নিয়মকানুন মেনে চলে না। এবার ৩য় বন্ধু বলে যে, আসলে বন্ধু, এটি মূলত এসবের জন্য হয়নি। বরং, এটা হয়েছে, আমার মতে, রাস্তার ব্যবহৃত কংক্রিটের জন্য। ভালো জিনিস দেয়া হয়নি, তাই এমনটা হয়েছে।

দেখুন, এখানে Given Fact ছিলো রাস্তার গর্ত। কিন্তু এটা দেখে ৩ জন বন্ধু তিনটি ভিন্ন সিদ্ধান্ত নিয়েছে। কারন তিন জন ব্যক্তির অভিজ্ঞতা তিন রকম। তাই একই ঘটনা তিন জন মানুষের মনে তিন রকম প্রভাব ফেলেছে। এক্ষেত্রে

১ম জন ভেবেছেন, নেতাদের উদাসীনতার জন্য এটা হয়েছে। এছাড়া অন্য কোনো কারন নেই। তাই তার সিদ্ধান্তটা এমন ছিল।

২য় জন ভেবেছেন, জনগণ হলো রাস্তাঘাট না থাকার জন্য দায়ী।

৩য় জন ভেবেছেন, মূলত রাস্তায় ব্যবহার করা কংক্রিট হল এর জন্য দায়ী।

এবার আপনি কিন্তু কাউকেই ভুল বলতে পারবেন না। কারণ আসল কারণ আপনি নিজেও জানেন না। এই যে আমাদের মনে বিভিন্ন রকম চিন্তা করে, যার উপর ভিত্তি করে আমরা সিদ্ধান্ত নিয়ে থাকি, এটাই হলো Assumption এবং আমাদের মূল টপিকের Assumption হবেঃ পরিবেশ দূষণরোধে ব্যক্তিগত প্রচেষ্টার সাথে প্রাতিষ্ঠানিক প্রচেষ্টার কোনো সম্পর্ক নেই। যেহেতু কিন্তু একটু চিন্তা করলেই আমরা বুঝতে পারবো যে ব্যক্তিগত প্রচেষ্টার সাথে প্রাতিষ্ঠানিক প্রচেষ্টার অবশ্যই একটি সম্পর্ক আছে এবং থাকতেই পারে। ধরি "ক" একটি প্রতিষ্ঠান যারা মূলত বিভিন্ন ব্যক্তিপর্যায়ে অর্থায়ন করে থাকে পরিবেশবান্ধব প্রকল্প বাস্তবায়নে। এখন তারা ১০ বছর একটি নির্দিষ্ট এলাকায় কাজ করে দেখিয়েছে যে উক্ত এলাকায় কার্বন নিঃসরণ কমেছে। তাহলে তারা যে কাজ সম্পন্ন করলো সেটা তো ব্যক্তি পর্যায়ের উদ্দ্যোগের মাধ্যমেই হচ্ছে। অর্থাৎ, ব্যক্তিগত প্রচেষ্টার সাথে প্রাতিষ্ঠানিক প্রচেষ্টার অবশ্যই একটি সম্পর্ক আছে তা এই Argument টি ভুলে যাচ্ছে, তাইনা? এছাড়া, আসলেই এই ব্যক্তিগত প্রচেষ্টার সাথে প্রাতিষ্ঠানিক প্রচেষ্টার কোনো সম্পর্ক আছে কিনা তা নিয়েও কোনো কিছু বলা হয়নি, তাই সিদ্ধান্তটি সঠিক কিনা তাও যাচাই করার উপায় নেই। আমাদের আরো তথ্য দরকার যা দিয়ে আমরা Argument টিকে বিশ্লেষণ করতে পারবো। এইতো, আপনি মূল বিষয় টা ধরে ফেলেছেন। এটা চিন্তা করাটাই হলো এই ধরণের লেখার মূল উপকরণ। যেহেতু এখানে বিস্তারিত কিছুই বলা নেই, তাই উপরের কথাটা সত্য বা মিথ্যা যেকোনোটাই হতে পারে। কিন্তু ভুল বলা যাবে না। তাই আমাদের আরো বেশি তথ্য জানা দরকার। তাহলেই ঘটনার আসল কারণ জানা যাবে। এটাই হলো Analysis.

অর্থাৎ, এখানে যা বলা হবে, তা ভুল বলা যাবে না কিন্তু সঠিক বলার দরকার নেই। অনেকটা নিরপেক্ষ অবস্থান নিতে হবে।

এবার আমরা দেখব, কিভাবে এই ধরণের লেখা লিখতে হয়। মূলত এই ধরণের লেখাতে নিচের মত একটা ফরম্যাট মেনে চলতে পারলে ভাল হয়।

প্রথমেই একটি Introduction থাকবে এবং শেষে একটি Conclusion থাকবে। এই দুইটির মধ্যে থাকবে Body বা মূল অংশ। Body তে ১ম ভাগে Assumption কে Attack করতে হবে। যেহেতু আমরা আমাদের Assumption এর উপর ভিত্তি করে Conclusion নিয়ে থাকি, তাই এর পর Conclusion কে Attack করতে হবে। এর উপর প্রশ্নে যা দেয়া আছে, তার সমর্থনে কিছু বলতে হবে এবং একেবারে শেষে গিয়ে পুনরায় বুঝাতে হবে যে পর্যাপ্ত তথ্য থাকাটা এখানে জরুরী। কিন্তু কোনভাবেই বলা যাবে না যে যা বলা হয়েছে তা ভুল বা সঠিক। অর্থাৎ আমরা পুরো লেখাতে নিচের মতো একটা উপস্থাপনা পাচ্ছি।

এবার প্রথমেই কথা বলবো, Introduction নিয়ে। মনে রাখবেন Introduction হলো আপনার লেখার দর্পণের মতো। এতে পরীক্ষক যেন আপনার চিন্তার পুরোটাই দেখতে পান। বেশিরভাগ ক্ষেত্রে যখন লিখতে দেয়া হয়, একটা বিষয় লক্ষ্যনীয়, আমাদের শব্দ ভান্ডারের সীমাবদ্ধতা। যদি আমাদের উপরের টপিকের উপর লিখতে বলা হয়ঃ

অনেকেই নিচের মতো লিখবেন Introduction অংশে।

Yes, I think environmental problem is a very big problem and organizations should take some steps.

কিন্তু দেখুন, আপনি একটি বিষয়কে বিশ্লেষণ করতে গিয়ে যদি এমন শুরু করেন, যিনি খাতাটি চেক করবেন, তিনি প্রথমেই একটু বিরক্ত হবে। কারণ লেখার মধ্যে থাকা চাই, একটা প্রফেশনাল ভাব এবং সাথে থাকবে, এমন কিছু শব্দ যা পরীক্ষককে শুরুতেই বুঝিয়ে দেবে আপনার দক্ষতা কতটা এই ধরণের লেখায়। Introduction অংশে আমরা মোট ৩/৪ টি বাক্য নিচ্ছি।

1. The given argument/statement claims that……..
2. Stated in this way, the argument/statement fails to take many pivotal factors into consideration while making the conclusion flawed.
3. Moreover, the assumption of the argument/statement primarily relies on some blanket assertions for which no transparent evidence is provided, so the argument/statement remains fallacious and open for debate.

এখানে ------- অংশে প্রশ্নে যা বলা আছে, তাই বলতে হবে তবে একটু ঘুরিয়ে যেন প্রশ্নের Statement টা কপি না হয় যায়। তাই পুরো লেখাটা একবারে লিখলে নিচের মতো হবে।

The given statement claims that the vastness of environmental problems necessitates steps taken by Government and large companies as individual efforts don't suffice. Stated in this way, the statement fails to take many pivotal factors into consideration while making the conclusion flawed. Moreover, the assumption of the argument primarily relies on some blanket assertions for which no transparent evidence is provided, so the argument remains fallacious and open for debate.

দেখুন, তো কত সুন্দর লাগছে এবার। আপনি কিন্তু বেশ কিছু সুন্দর শব্দ এখানে প্রয়োগ করেছেন, যা আপনার লেখার মধ্যে একটা ভিন্নতা নিয়ে এসেছে। এই ফরমেট টা মুখস্ত করার দরকার নেই। আপনি নিজের মত করে একটি প্রস্তুত করে নিন। কারণ আলোচনার শেষে আমরা ২০ টি নমুনা উত্তর দিয়েছি, যেগুলো থেকে আপনি চাইলে নিজের মত একটি ফরমেট তৈরি করে নিতে পারেন।

আমাদের এবার Assumption এর উপর আঘাত আনতে হবে। কারণ প্রতিটি মানুষ তার Assumption এর উপর ভিত্তি করেই সিদ্ধান্ত নিয়ে থাকে। এই কাজের জন্য আপনি নিচের ফরমেটটি ব্যবহার করত পারেন।

1. To begin with, the given argument readily assumes that ----------, for which no evidence is cited.
2. But to strengthen the situation, some factors/questions should be addressed. For example, …….. so that the validity of the argument could be realized.
3. So, the assumption is weak and not conclusive as the above-mentioned significant factors are not explicitly stated here.

এখানে প্রথম বাক্যের শূন্যস্থানে আপনি Assumption কে উল্লেখ করবেন। ২য় বাক্যে কমপক্ষে তিনটি দিক তুলে ধরবেন, যার উপর ভিত্তি করে Assumption এর সত্যতা যাচাই করা যায় বা যা Assumption এর দুর্বল দিক তুলে ধরবে। যেমন নিচের লেখাটি দেখুন।

To begin with, the given argument readily assumes that there is no correlation between institutional efforts and individual efforts, for which no evidence is cited. But to strengthen the situation, some questions should be addressed. For example, the author should mention steps adopted Government and large companies to curb damages being done to the environment. Besides, individual measures should also be mentioned. Unless it is established that there is no relation between efforts taken by Government and larges companies, and efforts taken by individuals, one shouldn't jump to conclusion. Therefore, this relation should be substantiated so that the validity of the argument could be realized. So, the assumption is weak and not conclusive as the above-mentioned significant factors are not explicitly stated here.

এবার আপনাকে যেটা করতে হবে তাহলো, Conclusion কে দুর্বল করে দেয়া। যেহেতু আপনি Assumption এর উপর আঘাত হেনেছেন, সেহেতু, Conclusion এমনিতেই দুর্বল হয়ে গিয়েছে। তাই নিচের ফরম্যাটটি অনুসরণ করতে পারেন।

Consequently, the conclusion of the argument/statement becomes unsubstantiated as no valid relation between the assumption and conclusion is established yet. So, once the above-mentioned factors are mentioned, the correlation between assumption and conclusion should be transparent.

এবার Final Statement এ গিয়ে আপনার কাজ হলো এটা জানিয়ে দেয়া কিছু ক্ষেত্রে Statement এ যা বলা আছে, তা ঠিক হলেও তা যে সর্বদাই প্রযোজ্য হবে তা নয়। যেহেতু সব কিছু পরিষ্কার ভাবে বলা হয়নি, তাই সহজেই এর সত্যতা প্রমাণিত হয় না। এর জন্য নিচের ফরম্যাটটি অনুসরণ করুন।

1. Finally, in spite of validity in some cases – to apply it universally – more studies should be conducted to establish a robust correlation between ---------- and ----------.

Finally, in spite of validity in some cases – to apply it universally – more studies should be conducted to establish a robust correlation between individual efforts and efforts taken by larges institutions.

দেখুন, ঘুরে ফিরে আপনি কিন্তু একই জায়গাতে নিয়ে এসেছেন, তাইনা। এবার আপনি Conclusion লিখবেন। নিচের ফরম্যাটটা অনুসরণ করুন।

1. In conclusion, this argument is not convincing as it stands. To strengthen it, the author would have to show that ……
2. Additionally, the author must provide evidences required to ……..

নিচের লেখাটা দেখুন।

In conclusion, this argument is not convincing as it stands. To strengthen it, the author would have to show that institutional attempts to tame environmental damages can be executed without individual endeavors. Additionally, the author must provide evidences required to demonstrate efficacy of attempts taken by Government and large companies.

এবার, সম্পূর্ণ লেখাটি দেখা যাক।

**Question:** The environment problems facing today's world are so great that there is little ordinary people can do to improve the situation. Government and large companies should be responsible for reducing the amount of damage being done to the environment.
*To what extent do you agree or disagree with this statement. Give reasons for your answer and include any relevant examples from your own knowledge or experience.*

**Answer:**
The given statement claims that the vastness of environmental problems necessitates steps taken by Government and large companies as individual efforts don't suffice. Stated in this way, the statement fails to take many pivotal factors into consideration while making the conclusion flawed. Moreover, the assumption of the argument primarily relies on some blanket assertions for which no transparent evidence is provided, so the argument remains fallacious and open for debate.
To begin with, the given argument readily assumes that there is no correlation between institutional efforts and individual efforts, for which no evidence is cited. But to strengthen the situation, some questions should be addressed. For example, the author should mention steps adopted Government and large companies to curb damages being done to the environment. Besides, individual measures should also be mentioned. Unless it is established that there is no relation between efforts taken by Government and larges companies, and efforts taken by individuals, one shouldn't jump to conclusion. Therefore, this relation should be substantiated so that the validity of the argument could be realized. So, the assumption is weak and not conclusive as the above-mentioned significant factors are not explicitly stated here.
Consequently, the conclusion of the argument/statement becomes unsubstantiated as no valid relation between the assumption and conclusion is established yet. So, once the above-mentioned factors are mentioned, the correlation between assumption and conclusion should be transparent.
Finally, in spite of validity in some cases – to apply it universally – more studies should be conducted to establish a robust correlation between individual efforts and efforts taken by larges institutions.
In conclusion, this argument is not convincing as it stands. To strengthen it, the author would have to show that institutional attempts to tame environmental damages can be executed without individual endeavors. Additionally, the author must provide evidences required to demonstrate efficacy of attempts taken by Government and large companies.

একই প্রশ্নের বিভিন্ন রকমের উত্তর হতে পারে। এখানে সঠিক বা ভুল বলা যায় না কোনো উত্তরকেই। পুরো ব্যাপারটা নির্ভর করে আপনি কোন দিক হতে বিশ্লেষণ করতে চাচ্ছেন। এ পর্যায়ে আমরা GMAT পরীক্ষায় আসে এমন কয়েকটি প্রশ্নের উত্তর দিচ্ছি। এগুলো সবকিছুই gmatclub.com এ গেলে পাবেন। কিন্তু শিখার জন্য আমাদের কাছে জরুরী মনে হয়েছে, তাই আমরা এখানে এগুলো দিয়ে দিচ্ছি। মূলত এগুলো পড়ার মাধ্যমে আপনি নিজের জন্য একটি ফরম্যাট বানাতে পারবেন, কেননা সবাই যদি উপরের ফরম্যাট টা ব্যবহার করে, তাহলে সবার লেখা প্রায় একই রকম হয়ে যাবে।

**Question 01:** The following appeared as part of an annual report sent to stockholders by Olympic Foods, a processor of frozen foods.

"Over time, the costs of processing go down because as organizations learn how to do things better, they become more efficient. In color film processing, for example, the cost of a 3-by-5-inch print fell from 50 cents for five-day service in 1970 to 20 cents for one-day service in 1984. The same principle applies to the processing of food. And since Olympic Foods will soon celebrate its twenty-fifth birthday, we can expect that our long experience will enable *us to minimize costs and thus maximize profits."*

*Discuss how well reasoned you find this argument. In your discussion be sure to analyze the line of reasoning and the use of evidence in the argument. For example, you may need to consider what questionable assumptions underlie the thinking and what alternative explanations or counterexamples might weaken the conclusion. You can also discuss what sort of evidence would strengthen or refute the argument, what changes in the argument would make it more logically sound, and what, if anything, would help you better evaluate its conclusion.*

Citing facts drawn from the color-film processing industry that indicate a downward trend in the costs of film processing over a 24-year period, the author argues that Olympic Foods will likewise be able to minimize costs and thus maximize profits in the future. In support of this conclusion the author cites the general principle that "as organizations learn how to do things better, they become more efficient." This principle, coupled with the fact that Olympic Foods has had 25 years of experience in the food processing industry leads to the author's rosy prediction. This argument is unconvincing because it suffers from two critical flaws.

First, the author's forecast of minimal costs and maximum profits rests on the gratuitous assumption that Olympic Foods' "long experience" has taught it how to do things better. There is, however, no guarantee that this is the case. Nor does the author cite any evidence to support this assumption. Just as likely, Olympic Foods has learned nothing from its 25 years in the food-processing business. Lacking this assumption, the expectation of increased efficiency is entirely unfounded.

Second, it is highly doubtful that the facts drawn from the color-film processing industry are applicable to the food processing industry. Differences between the two industries clearly outweigh the similarities, thus making the analogy highly less than valid. For example, problems of spoilage, contamination, and timely transportation all affect the food industry but are virtually absent in the film-processing industry. Problems such as these might present insurmountable obstacles that prevent lowering food-processing costs in the future.

As it stands the author's argument is not compelling. To strengthen the conclusion that Olympic Foods will enjoy minimal costs and maximum profits in the future, the author would have to provide evidence that the company has learned how to do things better as a result of its 25 years of experience. Supporting examples drawn from industries more similar to the food-processing industry would further substantiate the author's view.

**Question 02:** "When the Apogee Company had all its operations in one location, it was more profitable than it is today. Therefore, the Apogee Company should close down its field offices and conduct all its operations from a single location. Such centralization would improve profitability by cutting costs and helping the company maintain better supervision of all employees."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

In this argument the author concludes that the Apogee Company should close down field offices and conduct all its operations from a single, centralized location because the company had been more profitable in the past when all its operations were in one location. For a couple of reasons, this argument is not very convincing.

First, the author assumes that centralization would improve profitability by cutting costs and streamlining supervision of employees. This assumption is never supported with any data or projections. Moreover, the assumption fails to take into account cost increases and inefficiency that could result from centralization. For instance, company representatives would have to travel to do business in areas formerly served by a field office, creating travel costs and loss of critical time. In short, this assumption must be supported with a thorough cost-benefit analysis of centralization versus other possible cost-cutting and/or profit-enhancing strategies.

Second, the only reason offered by the author is the claim that Apogee was more profitable when it had operated from a single, centralized location. But is centralization the only difference relevant to greater past profitability? It is entirely possible that management has become lax regarding any number of factors that can affect the bottom line such as inferior products, careless product pricing, inefficient production, poor employee expense account monitoring, ineffective advertising, sloppy buying policies and other wasteful spending. Unless the author can rule out other factors relevant to diminishing profits, this argument commits the fallacy of assuming that just because one event (decreasing profits) follows another (decentralization), the second event has been caused by the first.

In conclusion, this is a weak argument. To strengthen the conclusion that Apogee should close field offices and centralize, this author must provide a thorough cost-benefit analysis of available alternatives and rule out factors other than decentralization that might be affecting current profits negatively.

**Question 03:** "In a recent citywide poll, fifteen percent more residents said that they watch television programs about the visual arts than was the case in a poll conducted five years ago. During these past five years, the number of people visiting our city's art museums has increased by a similar percentage. Since the corporate funding that supports public television, where most of the visual arts programs appear, is now being threatened with severe cuts, we can expect that attendance at our city's art museums will also start to decrease. Thus some of the city's funds for supporting the arts should be reallocated to public television."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

In this argument the author concludes that the city should allocate some of its arts funding to public television. The conclusion is based on two facts: (1) attendance at the city's art museum has increased proportionally with the increases in visual-arts program viewing on public television, and (2) public television is being threatened by severe cuts in corporate funding. While this argument is somewhat convincing, a few concerns need to be addressed.

To begin with, the argument depends on the assumption that increased exposure to the visual arts on television, mainly public television, has caused a similar increase in local art-museum attendance. However, just because increased art-museum attendance can be statistically correlated with similar increases in television viewing of visual-arts programs, this does not necessarily mean that the increased television viewing of arts is the cause of the rise in museum attendance.

Moreover, perhaps there are other factors relevant to increased interest in the local art museum; for instance, maybe a new director had procured more interesting, exciting acquisitions and exhibits during the period when museum attendance increased, in addition, the author could be overlooking a common cause of both increases. It is possible that some larger social or cultural phenomenon is responsible for greater public interest in both television arts programming and municipal art museums.

To be fair, however, we must recognize that the author's assumption is a special case of a more general one that television viewing affects people's attitudes and behavior. Common sense and observation tell me that this is indeed the case. After all, advertisers spend billions of dollars on television ad time because they trust this assumption as well.

In conclusion, I am somewhat persuaded by this author's line of reasoning. The argument would be strengthened if the author were to consider and rule out other significant factors that might have caused the increase in visits to the local art museum.

**Question 04:** "The falling revenues that the company is experiencing coincide with delays in manufacturing. These delays, in turn, are due in large part to poor planning in purchasing metals. Consider further that the manager of the department that handles purchasing of raw materials has an excellent background in general business, psychology, and sociology, but knows little about the properties of metals. The company should, therefore, move the purchasing manager to the sales department and bring in a scientist from the research division to be manager of the purchasing department."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

In response to a coincidence between falling revenues and delays in manufacturing, the report recommends replacing the manager of the purchasing department. The grounds for this action are twofold. First, the delays are traced to poor planning in purchasing metals. Second, the purchasing manager's lack of knowledge of the properties of metals is thought to be the cause of the poor planning. It is further recommended that the position of the purchasing manager be filled by a scientist from the research division and that the current purchasing manager be reassigned to the sales department. In support of this latter recommendation, the report states that the current purchasing manager's background in general business, psychology, and sociology equip him for this new assignment. The recommendations advanced in the report are questionable for two reasons.

To begin with, the report fails to establish a causal connection between the falling revenues of the company and the delays in manufacturing. The mere fact that falling revenues coincide with delays in manufacturing is insufficient to conclude that the delays caused the decline in revenue. Without compelling evidence to support the causal connection between these two events, the report's recommendations are not worthy of consideration.

Second, a central assumption of the report is that knowledge of the properties of metals is necessary for planning in purchasing metals. No evidence is stated in the report to support this crucial assumption. Moreover, it is not obvious that such knowledge would be required to perform this task. Since planning is essentially a logistical function, it is doubtful that in-depth knowledge of the properties of metals would be helpful in accomplishing this task.

In conclusion, this is a weak argument. To strengthen the recommendation that the manager of the purchasing department be replaced, the author would have to demonstrate that the falling revenues were a result of the delays in manufacturing. Additionally, the author would have to show that knowledge of the properties of metals is a prerequisite for planning in purchasing metals.

**Question 05:** "Since a competing lower-priced newspaper, The Bugle, was started five years ago, The Mercury's circulation has declined by 10,000 readers. The best way to get more people to read The Mercury is to reduce its price below that of The Bugle, at least until circulation increases to former levels. The increased circulation of The Mercury will attract more businesses to buy advertising space in the paper."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

A newspaper publisher is recommending that the price of its paper, The Mercury, be reduced below the price of a competing newspaper, The Bugle. This recommendation responds to a severe decline in circulation of The Mercury during the 5-year period following the introduction of The Bugle. The publisher's line of reasoning is that lowering the price of The Mercury will increase its readership, thereby increasing profits because a wider readership attracts more advertisers. This line of reasoning is problematic in two critical respects.

While it is clear that increased circulation would make the paper more attractive to potential advertisers, it is not obvious that lowering the subscription price is the most effective way to gain new readers. The publisher assumes that price is the only factor that caused the decline in readership. But no evidence is given to support this claim. Moreover, given that The Mercury was the established local paper, it is unlikely that such a mass exodus of its readers would be explained by subscription price alone.

There are many other factors that might account for a decline in The Mercury's popularity. For instance, readers might be displeased with the extent and accuracy of its news reporting, or the balance of local to other news coverage. Moreover, it is possible The Mercury has recently changed editors, giving the paper a locally unpopular political perspective. Or perhaps readers are unhappy with the paper's format, the timeliness of its feature articles, its comics or advice columns, the extent and accuracy of its local event calendar, or its rate of errors.

In conclusion, this argument is weak because it depends on an oversimplified assumption about the causal connection between the price of the paper and its popularity. To strengthen the argument, the author must identify and explore relevant factors beyond cost before concluding that lowering subscription prices will increase circulation and, thereby, increase advertising revenues.

**Question 06:** "Corporations should look to the city of Helios when seeking new business opportunities or a new location. Even in the recent recession, Helios's unemployment rate was lower than the regional average. It is the industrial center of the region, and historically it has provided more than its share of the region's manufacturing jobs. In addition, Helios is attempting to expand its economic base by attracting companies that focus on research and development of innovative technologies."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

In this argument corporations are urged to consider the city of Helios when seeking a new location or new business opportunities. To support this recommendation, the author points out that Helios is the industrial center of the region, providing most of the region's manufacturing jobs and enjoying a lower-than-average unemployment rate. Moreover, it is argued, efforts are currently underway to expand the economic base of the city by attracting companies that focus on research and development of innovative technologies. This argument is problematic for two reasons.

To begin with, it is questionable whether the available labor pool in Helios could support all types of corporations. Given that Helios has attracted mainly industrial and manufacturing companies in the past, it is unlikely that the local pool of prospective employees would be suitable for corporations of other types. For example, the needs of research and development companies would not be met by a labor force trained in manufacturing skills. For this reason, it's unlikely that Helios will be successful in its attempt to attract companies that focus or research and development of innovative technologies.

Another problem with the available work force is its size. Due to the lower than average unemployment rate in Helios, corporations that require large numbers of workers would not find Helios attractive. The fact that few persons are out of work suggests that new corporations will have to either attract new workers to Helios or pay the existing workers higher wages in order to lure them away from their current jobs. Neither of these alternatives seems enticing to companies seeking to relocate.

In conclusion, the author has not succeeded in providing compelling reasons for selecting Helios as the site for a company wishing to relocate. In fact, the reasons offered function better as reasons for not relocating to Helios. Nor has the author provided compelling reasons for companies seeking new business opportunities to choose Helios.

**Question 07:** "People who use the artificial sweetener aspartame are better off consuming sugar, since aspartame can actually contribute to weight gain rather than weight loss. For example, high levels of aspartame have been shown to trigger a craving for food by depleting the brain of a chemical that registers satiety, or the sense of being full. Furthermore, studies suggest that sugars, if

consumed after at least 45 minutes of continuous exercise, actually enhance the body's ability to burn fat. Consequently, those who drink aspartame-sweetened juices after exercise will also lose this calorie-burning benefit. Thus it appears that people consuming aspartame rather than sugar are unlikely to achieve their dietary goals."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

In this argument the author concludes that people trying to lose weight are better off consuming sugar than the artificial sweetener aspartame. To support this conclusion the author argues that aspartame can cause weight gain by triggering food cravings, whereas sugar actually enhances the body's ability to burn fat. Neither of these reasons provides sufficient support for the conclusion.

The first reason that aspartame encourages food cravings is supported by research findings that high levels of aspartame deplete the brain chemical responsible for registering a sense of being sated, or full. But the author's generalization based on this research is unreliable. The research was based on a sample in which large amounts of aspartame were administered; however, the author applies the research findings to a target population that includes all aspartame users, many of whom would probably not consume high levels of the artificial sweetener.

The second reason that sugar enhances the body's ability to burn fat is based on the studies in which experimental groups, whose members consumed sugar after at least 45 minutes of continuous exercise, showed increased rates of fat burning. The author's general claim, however, applies to all dieters who use sugar instead of aspartame, not just to those who use sugar after long periods of exercise. Once again, the author's generalization is unreliable because it is based on a sample that clearly does not represent all dieters.

To conclude, each of the studies cited by the author bases its findings on evidence that does not represent dieters in general; for this reason, neither premise of this argument is a reliable generalization. Consequently, I am not convinced that dieters are better off consuming sugar instead of aspartame.

**Question 08:** "On average, middle-aged consumers devote 39 percent of their retail expenditure to department store products and services, while for younger consumers the average is only 25 percent. Since the number of middle-aged people will increase dramatically within the next decade, department stores can expect retail sales to increase significantly during that period. Furthermore, to take advantage of the trend, these stores should begin to replace some of those products intended to attract the younger consumer with products intended to attract the middle-aged consumer."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

**Sample essay 1:**

The argument that department retail sales will increase in the next 10 years and thus department stores should begin to replace products to attract middle-aged consumers is not entirely logically convincing, since it omits certain crucial assumptions

First of all, the argument ignores the absolute amount of retail expenditure of middle-aged and younger consumers devoted to department store products and services. Although younger consumers spend a smaller percentage of their retail expenditure to department store products than do the middle-aged consumers, they might actually spend more in terms of the absolute amount.

Even if middle-aged consumers are spending more than younger ones in department stores, the argument ignores the possibility that the trend may change within the next decade. Younger consumers might prefer to shop in department stores than in other types of stores, and middle-aged consumers might turn to other types of stores, too. This will lead to a higher expenditure of younger consumers in department stores than that of middle-aged consumers.

Besides, the argument never addresses the population difference between middle-aged consumers and younger ones. Suppose there are more younger consumers than the middle-aged ones now, the total population base of younger consumers will be bigger than that of the middle-aged ones if both of them grow at the same rate in the next decade. Thus there will be a bigger younger consumer base.

Based on the reasons I listed above, the argument is not completely sound. The evidence in support of the conclusion does little to prove the conclusion since it does not address the assumptions I have already raised. Ultimately, the argument might have been more convincing by making it clear that the absolute population of middle-aged consumers are higher than that of the younger consumers and the number will continue to grow in the next decade, and that the middle-aged consumers will continue to spend more money in department stores than younger consumers do in the next decade.

**Sample essay 2:**

The argument that retailers should replace some of the products intended to attract the younger consumers with products intended to attract the middle-aged consumers is not entirely logically convincing, since it ignores certain crucial assumptions.

First, the argument omits the assumption that the business volumes of both the middle-aged consumers and the younger consumers are the same. If the business volume of the middle-aged consumers' 39% is smaller than that of the younger consumers' 25%, the retail sales will not increase during the next decade.

Second, even if the business volumes of both the middle-aged consumers and the younger consumers were the same in the last decade, the increase of the middle-aged people in the next decade is not the same as the increase of the retail expenditure, for the retail trade depends more on such factors as the economic circumstances, people's consuming desire.

Finally, the argument never assumes the increase of the younger consumers within the next decade. If the younger consumers increase at the same rate and spend the same amount of money on the goods and services of department stores, the retailers should never ignore them.

Thus the argument is not completely sound. The evidence in support of the conclusion that the growing number of middle-aged people within the next decade does little to prove the conclusion—that department stores should begin to replace some of their products to attract the middle-aged consumers since it does not address the assumptions I have already raised. Ultimately, the argument might have been strengthened by making it clear that the business volumes of both types of consumers are the same and comparable, that the increase of a certain type of consumers are correlated with the increase of the retail sales, and that the growth rate of the younger consumers are the same as that of the middle-aged consumers.

**Sample essay 3:**

Based on an expected increase in the number of middle-aged people during the next decade, the author predicts that retail sales at department stores will increase significantly over the next ten years. To bolster this prediction, the author cites statistics showing that middle-aged people devote a much higher percentage of their retail expenditure to department-store services and products than younger consumers do. Since the number of middle-aged consumers is on the rise and since they spend more than younger people on department-store goods and services, the author further recommends that department stores begin to adjust their inventories to capitalize on this trend. Specifically, it is recommended that department stores increase their inventory of products aimed at middle-aged consumers and decrease their inventory of products aimed at younger consumers. This argument is problematic for two reasons.

First, an increase in the number of middle-aged people does not necessarily portend an overall increase in department-store sales. It does so only on the assumption that other population groups will remain relatively constant. For example, if the expected increase in the number of middle-aged people is offset by an equally significant decrease in the number of younger people, there will be little or no net gain in sales.

Second, in recommending that department stores replace products intended to attract younger consumers with products more suitable to middle-aged consumers, the author assumes that the number of younger consumers will not also increase. Since a sizable increase in the population of younger consumers could conceivably offset the difference in the retail expenditure patterns of younger and middle-aged consumers, it would be unwise to make the recommended inventory adjustment lacking evidence to support this assumption.

In conclusion, this argument is unacceptable. To strengthen the argument the author would have to provide evidence that the population of younger consumers will remain relatively constant over the next decade.

**Question 9:** "This past winter, 200 students from Waymarsh State College traveled to the state capitol building to protest against proposed cuts in funding for various state college programs. The other 12,000 Waymarsh students evidently weren't so concerned about their education: they either stayed on campus or left for winter break. Since the group who did not protest is far more numerous, it is more representative of the state's college students than are the protesters. Therefore the state legislature need not heed the appeals of the protesting students."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

The conclusion in this argument is that the state legislature need not consider the views of protesting students. To support this conclusion, the author points out that only 200 of the 12,000 students traveled to the state capitol to voice their concerns about proposed cuts in college programs. Since the remaining students did not take part in this protest, the author concludes they are not interested in this issue. The reasoning in this argument is flawed for two reasons.

First, the author assumes that because only one-tenth of the students took part in the protest, these students' views are unrepresentative of the entire student body. This assumption is unwarranted. If it turns out, for example, that the protesting students were randomly selected from the entire student body, their views would reflect the views of the entire college. Without information regarding the way in which the protesting students were selected, it is presumptuous to conclude that their opinions fail to reflect the opinions of their colleagues.

Second, the author cites the fact that the remaining 12,000 students stayed on campus or left for winter break as evidence that they are not concerned about their education. One obvious rejoinder to this line of reasoning is that the students who did not participate did so with the knowledge that their concerns would be expressed by the protesting students. In any case, the author has failed to demonstrate a logical connection between the students' alleged lack of concern and the fact that they either stayed on campus or left for winter break. Without this connection, the conclusion reached by the author that the remaining 12,000 students are not concerned about their education is unacceptable.

As it stands, the argument is not well reasoned. To make it logically acceptable, the author would have to demonstrate that the protesting students had some characteristic in common that biases their views, thereby nullifying their protest as representative of the entire college.

**Question 10:** "In the first four years that Montoya has served as mayor of the city of San Perdito, the population has decreased and the unemployment rate has increased. Two businesses have closed for each new business that has opened. Under Varro, who served as mayor for four years before Montoya, the unemployment rate decreased and the population increased. Clearly, the residents of San Perdito would be best served if they voted Montoya out of office and reelected Varro."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

The recommendation endorsed in this argument is that residents of San Perdito vote current mayor Montoya out of office, and re-elect former mayor Varro. The reasons cited are that during Montoya's four years in office the population has decreased while unemployment has increased, whereas during Varro's term unemployment declined while the population grew. This argument involves the sort of gross oversimplification and emotional appeal typical of political rhetoric; for this reason it is unconvincing.

First of all, the author assumes that the Montoya administration caused the unemployment in San Perdito as well as its population loss. The line of reasoning is that because Montoya was elected before the rise in unemployment and the decline in population, the former event caused the latter. But this is fallacious reasoning unless other possible causal explanations have been considered and ruled out. For example, perhaps a statewide or nationwide recession is the cause of these events. Or perhaps the current economic downturn is part of a larger picture of economic cycles and trends, and has nothing to do with who happens to be mayor. Yet another possibility is that Varro enjoyed a period of economic stability and Varro's own administration set the stage for the unemployment and the decline in population the city is now experiencing under Montoya.

Secondly, job availability and the economic health of one's community are issues that affect people emotionally. The argument at hand might have been intentionally oversimplified for the specific purpose of angering citizens of San Perdito, and thereby turning them against the incumbent mayor. Arguments that bypass relevant, complex reasoning in favor of stirring up emotions do nothing to establish their conclusions; they are also unfair to the parties involved.

In conclusion, I would not cast my vote for Varro on the basis of this weak argument. The author must provide support for the assumption that Mayor Montoya has caused San Perdito's poor economy. Moreover, such support would have to involve examining and eliminating other possible causal factors. Only with more convincing evidence could this argument become more than just an emotional appeal.

**Question 11:** "Advertising the reduced price of selected grocery items in the Daily Gazette will help you increase your sales. Consider the results of a study conducted last month. Thirty sale items from a store in downtown Marston were advertised in the Gazette for four days. Each time one or more of the 30 items was purchased, clerks asked whether the shopper had read the ad. Two-thirds of the 200 shoppers asked answered in the affirmative. Furthermore, more than half the customers who answered in the affirmative spent over $100 at the store."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

The conclusion of this argument is that advertising the reduced price of selected items in the Daily Gazette will result in increased sales overall. To support it, the author cites an informal poll conducted by sales clerks when customers purchased advertised items. Each time one or more of the advertised items was sold, the clerks asked whether the customer had read the ad. It turned out that two-thirds of 200 shoppers questioned said that they had read the ad. In addition, of those who reported reading the ad, more than half spent over $100 in the store. This argument is unconvincing for two reasons.

To begin with, the author's line of reasoning is that the advertisement was the cause of the purchase of the sale items. However, while the poll establishes a correlation between reading the ad and purchasing sale items, and also indicates a correlation, though less significantly, between reading the ad and buying non-sale items, it does not establish a general causal relationship between these events. To establish this relationship, other factors that could bring about this result must be considered and eliminated. For example, if the four days during which the poll was conducted preceded Thanksgiving and the advertised items were traditionally associated with this holiday, then the results of the poll would be extremely biased and unreliable.

Moreover, the author assumes that the poll indicates that advertising certain sale will cause a general increase in sales. But the poll does not even address the issue of increased overall sales; it informs us mainly that, of the people who purchased sales items, more had read the ad than not. A much clearer indicator of the ad's effectiveness would be a comparison of overall sales on days the ad ran with overall sales on otherwise similar days when the ad did not run.

In sum, this argument is defective mainly because the poll does not support the conclusion that sales in general will increase when reduced-price products are advertised in the Daily Gazette. To strengthen the argument, the author must, at the very least, provide comparisons of overall sales reports as described above.

**Question 12:** "The Cumquat Cafe began advertising on our local radio station this year and was delighted to see its business increase by 10 percent over last year's totals. Their success shows you how you can use radio advertising to make your business more profitable."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

In an attempt to sell radio advertising time, this ad claims that radio advertising will make businesses more profitable. The evidence cited is a ten percent increase in business that the Cumquat Cafe has experienced in the year during which it advertised on the local radio station. This argument is unconvincing because two questionable assumptions must be made for the stated evidence to support the author's conclusion.

The first assumption is that radio advertising alone has caused the increase in business at the Cumquat Cafe. This assumption is questionable because it overlooks a number of other factors that might have contributed to the Cumquat's success. For example, the Cumquat might have changed owners or chefs; it might have launched a coupon ad campaign in the local print media; or it might have changed or updated the menu. Yet another possibility is that a local competitor went out of business. These are just a few of the factors that could help explain the Cumquat's growth. Because the author fails to eliminate these possibilities, the assumption in question need not be accepted.

Even if it is granted that radio advertising is responsible for the Cumquat's success, another assumption must be made before we can conclude that radio advertising will result in increased profits for businesses in general. We must also assume that what is true of the Cumquat will likewise be true of most other businesses. But there are all kinds of important differences between cafes and other businesses that could affect how radio audiences react to their advertising. We cannot safely assume that because a small restaurant has benefited from radio advertising, any and all local businesses will similarly benefit.

In conclusion, it would be imprudent for a business to invest in radio advertising solely on the basis of the evidence presented. To strengthen the conclusion, it must be established that radio advertising was the principal cause of increased business at the Cumquat. Once this is shown, it must be determined that the business in question is sufficiently like the Cumquat, and so can expect similar returns from investment in radio ad time.

**Question 13:** "Two years ago Nova High School began to use interactive computer instruction in three academic subjects. The school dropout rate declined immediately, and last year's graduates have reported some impressive achievements in college. In future budgets the school board should use a greater portion of the available funds to buy more computers, and all schools in the district should adopt interactive computer instruction throughout the curriculum."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

**Sample essay 1:**

The argument that the school board should buy more computers and adopt interactive computer instruction is not entirely logically convincing, since it ignores certain crucial assumptions.

First, the argument assumes that the decline of school dropout and the achievements of last year's graduates' results from the adoption of interactive computer instruction. However, there are several reasons why this might not be true. For example, achievements could have been made in other subjects than the ones with interactive computer instruction. Or last years' graduates might not have been given the interactive computer instruction. Or the decline of the rate of dropout could be attributed to stricter discipline applied last year.

Second, even supposing the Nova High School's decline of the dropout and last year's graduates' achievements benefit directly from the usage of interactive computer instruction, the success of the instruction in one school may not ensure the success in other schools. If it does not suit other schools, the instruction will not work.

Finally, even if the decline of the rate of dropout and the achievements of the last year's graduates' are the direct results of the interactive computer instruction, we still do not know whether the school can afford to apply the instruction on all the subjects or to all the students. If the school does not have sufficient fund and has to cut budgets on other projects such as the library, the quality of the school's education will also compromise.

Thus, the argument is not completely sound. The evidence in support of the conclusion that the dropout rate declined and last year's graduates made impressive achievements does little to prove the conclusion that other schools should use a greater portion of their funds to apply the instruction since it does not address the assumptions I have already raised. Ultimately, the argument might have been strengthened by making it clear that the decline of the dropout rate and the achievements of the graduates are the direct results of interactive computer instruction, that the instruction is also applicable to other schools in the district, and that the instruction is affordable to all the schools in the district.

**Sample essay 2:**

The editorial recommends that the school board of Nova High spend a greater portion of available funds on the purchase of additional computers and adopt interactive computer instruction throughout the curriculum. Two reasons are offered in support of this recommendation. First, the introduction of interactive computer instruction in three academic subjects was immediately followed by a decline in the school dropout rate. Second, last year's graduates experienced impressive achievements in college. This argument is unconvincing for two reasons.

To begin with, this argument is a classic instance of "after this, therefore because of this" reasoning. The mere fact that the introduction of interactive computer instruction preceded the impressive performance of recent graduates and the decline in the dropout rate is insufficient to conclude that it was the cause of these events. Many other factors could bring about these same results. For example, the school may have implemented counseling and training programs that better meet the needs of students who might otherwise leave school to take jobs. In addition, the school may have introduced programs to better prepare students for college.

Secondly, the author assumes that the impressive achievements of last year's graduates bear some relation to the introduction of interactive computer instruction at Nova High. However, no evidence is offered to support this assumption. Lacking evidence that links the achievements of the recent graduates to the interactive instruction, it is presumptuous to suggest that the computer instruction was in some way responsible for the students' impressive performance.

In conclusion, the recommendation that Nova High spend a greater portion of available funds on the purchase of additional computers and adopt interactive computer instruction throughout the curriculum is ill-founded. To strengthen this recommendation the author would have to demonstrate that the decline in the dropout rate and the impressive performance of recent graduates came about as a result of the use of computer-interactive instruction. All that has been shown so far is a correlation between these events.

**Question 14:** "Re-elect Adams, and you will be voting for proven leadership in improving the state's economy. Over the past year alone, seventy percent of the state's workers have had increases in their wages, five thousand new jobs have been created, and six corporations have located their headquarters here. Most of the respondents in a recent poll said they believed that the economy is likely to continue to improve if Adams is reelected. Adams's opponent, Zebulon, would lead our state in the wrong direction, because Zebulon disagrees with many of Adams's economic policies."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

This political advertisement recommends re-electing Governor Adams because he has a proven leadership role in improving the state's economy. In support of this reason the author cites these statistics: in the past year, most state workers' wages have gone up; 5,000 new jobs have been created; and six corporations have located in the state. Another reason offered for re-electing Adams is a recent poll, which indicates that most respondents believe the state economy would continue to improve if he were re-elected. Finally, the author claims that rival Zebulon would harm the state's economy because he disagrees with Adams' fiscal policies. This argument is fraught with vague, oversimplified and unwarranted claims.

To begin with, the statistics are intended to support the main claim that the state is economically better off with Adams as governor. But these statistics are vague and oversimplified, and thus may distort the state's overall economic picture. For example, state workers' pay raises may have been minuscule and may not have kept up with cost of living or with pay for state workers in other states. Moreover, the 5,000 new jobs may have been too few to bring state unemployment rates down significantly; at the same time, many jobs may have been lost. Finally, the poll indicates that six new corporations located in the state, but fails to indicate if any left.

Next, the poll cited by the author is described in the vaguest possible terms. The ad does not indicate who conducted the poll, who responded, or how the poll was conducted. Until these questions are answered, the survey results are worthless as evidence for public opinion about Adams or his economic policies.

Finally, while we have only vague and possibly distorted evidence that the state is better off with Adams, we have absolutely no evidence that it would be worse off with Zebulon. Given that the state economy is good at the moment, none of the author's reasons establishes that Adams is the cause of this. And neither do they establish that the state wouldn't be even better off with someone else in office.

In conclusion, this argument is weak. To strengthen the argument, the author must provide additional information about the adequacy of state workers' pay raises, the effect of the 5,000 jobs on the state's employment picture, the overall growth of corporations in the state, and other features of the state economy. Also, the author must support the claims that Adams' actions have caused any economic improvement and that in the future Adams will impart more economic benefit than would Zebulon.

**Question 15:** "Throughout the last two decades, those who earned graduate degrees found it very difficult to get jobs teaching their academic specialties at the college level. Those with graduate degrees from Waymarsh University had an especially hard time finding such jobs. But better times are coming in the next decade for all academic job seekers, including those from Waymarsh. Demographic trends indicate that an increasing number of people will be reaching college age over the next ten years; consequently, we can expect that the job market will improve dramatically for people seeking college-level teaching positions in their fields."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

Demographic trends that indicate an increase in the number of college-aged people over the next ten years lead the author to predict an improved job market for all people seeking college-level teaching positions in their academic disciplines. Moreover, the author argues that since Waymarsh University students with advanced degrees had an especially difficult time finding teaching jobs in the past, these trends portend better times ahead for Waymarsh graduates. This argument is problematic in three important respects.

First, the author assumes that an increase in the number of college-aged people over the next decade will necessarily result in an increase in the number of people who attend college during this period. While this is a reasonable assumption, it is by no means a certainty. For example, a world war or economic depression in the next decade would certainly nullify this expectation.

Second, even if we grant the preceding assumption, we must also consider the additional assumption that increased university enrollments will lead to an increase in teaching positions in all fields. However, it might turn out that some teaching specialties are in greater demand than others in the future, resulting in a disproportionate number of teaching positions available in various fields. Consequently, persons trained in some fields might find it more difficult, if not impossible, to find teaching jobs in the future.

Finally, little can be foretold regarding the employability of Waymarsh graduates in the future based on the information provided in the argument. Lacking information about the reasons why Waymarsh graduates had an especially difficult time finding teaching jobs, it is difficult to assess their prospects for the future. It is probable, however, that since Waymarsh has had an especially hard time placing graduates in the past, the mere fact that more jobs are available will not, by itself, ensure that Waymarsh graduates will have an easier time finding teaching jobs during the next decade.

In conclusion, this argument is unconvincing. To strengthen the argument, the author must provide evidence that the only major trend in the next decade will be an increase in the number of people reaching college age. Regarding the future prospects for Waymarsh graduates, the author must provide evidence that there were no idiosyncratic reasons that prevented them from finding jobs in the past.

**Question 16:** "Two of today's best-selling brands of full-strength prescription medication for the relief of excess stomach acid, Acid-Ease and Pepticaid, are now available in milder nonprescription forms. Doctors have written 76 million more prescriptions for full-strength Acid-Ease than for full-strength Pepticaid. So people who need an effective but milder nonprescription medication for the relief of excess stomach acid should choose Acid-Ease."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

This ad recommends non-prescription Acid-Ease over non-prescription Pepticaid for relief of excess stomach acid. The only reason offered is that doctors have written 76 million more prescriptions for the full-strength prescription form of Acid-Ease than for full-strength Pepticaid. While this reason is relevant, and provides some grounds for preferring Acid-Ease over Pepticaid, it is insufficient as it stands because it depends on three unwarranted assumptions.

The first assumption is that the prescription form of Acid-Ease is more popular among doctors. But this might not be the case, even though doctors have written 76 million more prescriptions for Acid-Ease. Acid-Ease may have been available for several more years than Pepticaid; and in the years when both products were available, Pepticaid might have actually been prescribed more often than Acid-Ease.

The second assumption is that doctors prefer the prescription form of Acid-Ease for the reason that it is in fact more effective at relieving excess stomach acid. However, doctors may have preferred Acid-Ease for reasons other than its effectiveness. Perhaps Acid-Ease is produced by a larger, more familiar drug company or by one that distributes more free samples. For that matter, the medical community may have simply been mistaken in thinking that Acid-Ease was more effective. In short, the number of prescriptions by itself is not conclusive as to whether one product is actually better than another.

The third assumption is that the milder non-prescription forms of Acid-Ease and Pepticaid will be analogous to the full-strength prescription forms of each. But this might not be the case. Suppose for the moment that the greater effectiveness of prescription Acid-Ease has been established; even so, the non-prescription form might not measure up to non-prescription Pepticaid. This fact must be established independently.

In conclusion, this ad does not provide enough support for its recommending non-prescription Acid-Ease over non-prescription Pepticaid. To strengthen its argument, the promoter of Acid-Ease would have to show that (1) the comparison between the number of prescriptions is based on the same time period; (2) its effectiveness is the main reason more doctors have prescribed it, and (3) the comparative effectiveness of the two non-prescription forms is analogous to that of the prescription forms.

**Question 17:** "Neither stronger ethics regulations nor stronger enforcement mechanisms are necessary to ensure ethical behavior by companies doing business with this department. We already have a code of ethics that companies doing business with this department are urged to abide by, and virtually all of these companies have agreed to follow it. We also know that the code is relevant to the current business environment because it was approved within the last year, and in direct response to specific violations committed by companies with which we were then working—not in abstract anticipation of potential violations, as so many such codes are."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

In this argument, the head of a government department concludes that the department does not need to strengthen either its ethics regulations or its enforcement mechanisms in order to encourage ethical behavior by companies with which it does business. The first reason given is that businesses have agreed to follow the department's existing code of ethics. The second reason is that the existing code is relevant to the current business environment. This argument is unacceptable for several reasons.

The sole support for the claim that stronger enforcement mechanisms are unnecessary comes from the assumption that companies will simply keep their promises to follow the existing code. But, since the department head clearly refers to rules violations by these same businesses within the past year, his faith in their word is obviously misplaced. Moreover, it is commonly understood that effective rules carry with them methods of enforcement and penalties for violations.

To show that a strengthened code is unnecessary, the department head claims that the existing code of ethics is relevant. In partial clarification of the vague term "relevant," we are told that the existing code was approved in direct response to violations occurring in the past year. If the full significance of being relevant is that the code responds to last year's violations, then the department head must assume that those violations will be representative of all the kinds of ethics problems that concern the department. This is unlikely; in addition, thinking so produces an oddly short-sighted idea of relevance.

Such a narrow conception of the relevance of an ethics code points up its weakness. The strength of an ethics code lies in its capacity to cover many different instances of the general kinds of behavior thought to be unethical—to cover not only last year's specific violations, but those of previous years and years to come. Yet this author explicitly rejects a comprehensive code, preferring the existing code because it is "relevant" and "not in abstract anticipation of potential violations."

In sum, this argument is naive, vague and poorly reasoned. The department head has not given careful thought to the connection between rules and their enforcement, to what makes an ethics code relevant, or to how comprehensiveness strengthens a code. In the final analysis, he adopts a backwards view that a history of violations should determine rules of ethics, rather than the other way around.

**Question 18:** "Over the past decade, the restaurant industry in the country of Spiessa has experienced unprecedented growth. This surge can be expected to continue in the coming years, fueled by recent social changes: personal incomes are rising, more leisure time is available, single-person households are more common, and people have a greater interest in gourmet food, as evidenced by a proliferation of publications on the subject."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

Recent social changes in the country of Spiessa lead the author to predict a continued surge in growth of that country's restaurant industry. Rising personal incomes, additional leisure time, an increase in single-person households, and greater interest in gourmet food are cited as the main reasons for this optimistic outlook. All of these factors are indeed relevant to growth in the restaurant industry; so the prediction appears reasonable on its face. However, three questionable assumptions operative in this argument bear close examination.

The first dubious assumption is that the supply of restaurants in Spiessa will continue to grow at the same rate as in the recent past. However, even in the most favorable conditions and the best of economic times there are just so many restaurants that a given population can accommodate and sustain. It is possible that the demand for restaurants has already been met by the unprecedented growth of the past decade, in which case the recent social changes will have little impact on the growth of the restaurant industry.

A second assumption is that the economic and social circumstances cited by the author will actually result in more people eating out at restaurants. This assumption is unwarranted, however. For example, increased leisure time may just as likely result in more people spending more time cooking gourmet meals in their own homes. Also, single people may actually be more likely than married people to eat at home than to go out for meals. Finally, people may choose to spend their additional income in other ways—on expensive cars, travel, or larger homes.

A third poor assumption is that, even assuming people in Spiessa will choose to spend more time and money eating out, no extrinsic factors will stifle this demand. This assumption is unwarranted. Any number of extrinsic factors—such as a downturn in the general economy or significant layoffs at Spiessa's largest businesses—may stall the current restaurant surge. Moreover, the argument fails to specify the "social changes" that have led to the current economic boom. If it turns out these changes are politically driven, then the surge may very well reverse if political power changes hands.

In conclusion, this argument unfairly assumes a predictable future course for both supply and demand. To strengthen the argument, the author must at the very least show that demand for new restaurants has not yet been exhausted, that Spiessa can accommodate new restaurants well into the future, and that the people of Spiessa actually want to eat out more.

**Question 19:** "Laboratory studies show that Saluda Natural Spring Water contains several of the minerals necessary for good health and that it is completely free of bacteria. Residents of Saluda, the small town where the water is bottled, are hospitalized less frequently than the national average. Even though Saluda Natural Spring Water may seem expensive, drinking it instead of tap water is a wise investment in good health."

Discuss how well reasoned... etc.

**Sample essay 1:**

The argument that drinking Saluda Natural Spring Water instead of tap water is a wise investment in good health is not entirely logically convincing, since it lacks certain supporting factors.

Firstly, the argument assumes that Saluda Natural Spring Water is the major reason why residents of Saluda are less frequently hospitalized than the national average. However, there is little evidence that this water is the only difference between this place and the rest of the country. And the reason why people in other places are more hospitalized are numerous and varied. There are so many other factors that would bring people in other places to hospitals, such as accidents, food contamination, illnesses, etc.

Secondly, the argument also assumes that the minerals in Saluda National Spring Water are the key minerals for the good health of the residents of Saluda. However, this may not be true. We need not only minerals to keep good heath but also various vitamins. Besides, our body needs more minerals than those contained in Saluda Natural Spring Water.

Finally, even if the Saluda water is the major reason why the residents of Saluda are less hospitalized, the argument still omits the fact that there is more than one way to keep drinking water free from bacteria. For instance, the most common practice is to boil water up to 100 degree Celsius and keep it at that degree for more than 5 minutes. Therefore drinking Saluda water to keep good health is not the only alternative.

Thus, the argument is not completely sound. The evidence in support of the conclusion that the Saluda residents are less hospitalized does little to prove the conclusion that drinking Saluda Natural Spring Water is a wise investment in good health since it omits the assumptions I have just raised. The argument might have been strengthened by making it plain that Saluda Natural Spring Water is the major reason why the residents of Saluda are less hospitalized, that the water contains all the major minerals essential for the human body, and that there is no other way to keep water from bacteria.

**Sample essay 2:**

In this argument the author concludes that drinking Saluda Natural Spring Water (SNSW) is preferable to drinking tap water. Three reasons are offered in support of this conclusion: SNSW contains several of the minerals necessary for good health, it is completely tree of bacteria, and residents of Saluda—the town where it is bottled—are hospitalized less frequently than the national average. This argument is unconvincing because it relies on a variety of dubious assumptions.

The first questionable assumption underlying this argument that tap water does not contain the minerals in question and is not completely free of bacteria. This assumption is not supported in the argument. If tap water is found to contain the same minerals and to be free of bacteria, the author's conclusion is substantially undermined.

A second assumption of the argument is that the water residents of Saluda drink is the same as SNSW. Lacking evidence to the contrary, it is possible that Saluda is not the source of the bottled water but is merely the place where SNSW is bottled. No evidence is offered in the argument to dispute this possibility.

Finally, it is assumed without argument that the reason residents are hospitalized less frequently than the national average is that they drink SNSW. Again, no evidence is offered to support this assumption. Perhaps the residents are hospitalized less frequently because they are younger than the national average, because they are all vegetarians, or because they exercise daily. That is, there might be other reasons than the one cited to account for this disparity.

In conclusion, this is an unconvincing argument. To strengthen the conclusion that SNSW is more healthful than tap water, the author must provide evidence that tap water contains harmful bacteria not found in SNSW. Moreover, the author must demonstrate that the residents of Saluda regularly drink the same water as SNSW and that this is why they are hospitalized less frequently than the national average.